

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · July 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	81.0
#2	A+	Hartford	76.9
#3	A+	Cincinnati	73.3
#4	A+	Charlotte	72.9
#5	A+	Nashville	71.8
#6	A+	Kansas City	71.2
#7	A+	Austin	68.3

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Louisville	19.8
#49	D	Grand Rapids	20.3
#48	D	Chicago	25.5
#47	C-	Detroit	29.2
#46	C-	Jacksonville	31.9
#45	C	Richmond	32.6
#44	C	Sacramento	32.8

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	12 cities
B+ / B / B-	18 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	3 cities

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · July 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	81.0	3.0%	+3.8%	+2.6%	+0.6%	50 days
2	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	76.9	2.7%	+4.7%	+1.9%	+2.8%	29 days
3	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	73.3	3.1%	+6.4%	+1.1%	-1.0%	37 days
4	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	72.9	3.6%	+4.7%	+1.6%	+0.3%	51 days
5	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A+	71.8	2.8%	+6.0%	+1.6%	-0.8%	53 days
6	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	71.2	3.5%	+7.7%	+0.8%	-0.7%	45 days
7	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A+	68.3	3.5%	+4.7%	+1.9%	+0.4%	63 days
8	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A	66.0	3.4%	+4.2%	+2.7%	-0.1%	50 days
9	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A	65.3	3.2%	+3.1%	+0.4%	+1.6%	52 days
10	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	A	63.3	3.5%	+0.3%	+1.4%	-0.8%	37 days
11	St. Louis St. Louis	A-	61.6	3.6%	+2.0%	+0.4%	-0.7%	44 days
12	Memphis Memphis	A-	60.1	4.1%	+9.0%	+0.2%	-1.1%	64 days
13	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B+	56.4	4.4%	+5.0%	+1.4%	+1.1%	70 days
14	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	56.1	5.3%	+4.5%	+2.9%	+1.3%	55 days
15	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B+	56.0	3.8%	+5.6%	+0.1%	+2.0%	47 days
16	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B	52.6	4.0%	+1.9%	+1.3%	+0.2%	51 days
17	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	52.3	3.6%	+6.2%	+0.6%	-1.8%	37 days
18	Columbus Columbus	B	51.7	2.7%	+3.5%	+0.4%	-1.5%	39 days
19	Birmingham Birmingham	B	51.4	3.2%	+0.6%	+1.0%	-0.8%	54 days
20	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B	50.9	3.9%	+7.2%	+1.1%	-1.4%	43 days
21	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B	50.4	4.1%	+0.7%	+0.6%	+1.5%	39 days
22	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B	50.1	3.6%	+2.0%	+0.6%	-2.6%	48 days
23	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	48.7	4.8%	+6.4%	+0.3%	-0.3%	37 days
24	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	47.2	4.5%	+5.6%	+0.2%	-0.3%	68 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	46.9	4.3%	+2.8%	+0.7%	+0.5%	47 days
26	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	46.8	3.4%	-0.3%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
27	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B-	46.2	3.9%	+3.9%	-0.4%	-0.2%	36 days
28	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	46.0	4.1%	+2.4%	+1.4%	-1.3%	64 days
29	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	B-	44.7	3.2%	+1.6%	-0.4%	-0.1%	33 days
30	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	44.4	4.6%	+1.5%	+1.1%	+0.0%	50 days
31	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	C+	43.1	4.8%	+3.6%	+1.8%	-1.9%	50 days
32	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	43.1	3.9%	+3.2%	+0.4%	+2.9%	37 days
33	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	C+	42.2	4.2%	+5.1%	+0.1%	-1.1%	51 days
34	Fresno Fresno	C+	42.2	7.4%	+6.0%	+1.6%	0.0%	55 days
35	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	42.1	3.7%	+5.9%	-0.6%	-1.3%	37 days
36	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C+	41.8	3.9%	+5.2%	-2.4%	-2.7%	36 days
37	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	C+	40.7	3.6%	+6.9%	+0.2%	-0.9%	82 days
38	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	39.2	4.1%	+1.3%	+0.6%	-0.1%	61 days
39	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	37.8	4.6%	+6.2%	+0.7%	-2.3%	59 days
40	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	37.2	3.9%	+0.0%	+1.5%	-1.4%	37 days
41	Providence Providence-Warwick	C	36.7	4.3%	+3.0%	+0.6%	+1.7%	32 days
42	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C	36.3	3.0%	-0.7%	-1.3%	-0.2%	45 days
43	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	35.7	4.7%	+5.8%	-2.1%	-1.1%	51 days
44	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	32.8	4.2%	+1.1%	+0.7%	-1.5%	43 days
45	Richmond Richmond	C	32.6	3.5%	+2.6%	-0.7%	-1.0%	37 days
46	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C-	31.9	4.7%	-0.7%	+0.3%	-0.1%	59 days
47	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	29.2	5.5%	+1.1%	-0.2%	+2.2%	38 days
48	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	D	25.5	4.9%	+3.2%	+0.1%	-1.7%	33 days
49	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	D	20.3	4.4%	+2.0%	-0.3%	-6.2%	33 days
50	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	D	19.8	4.6%	+1.2%	-0.5%	-1.0%	40 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

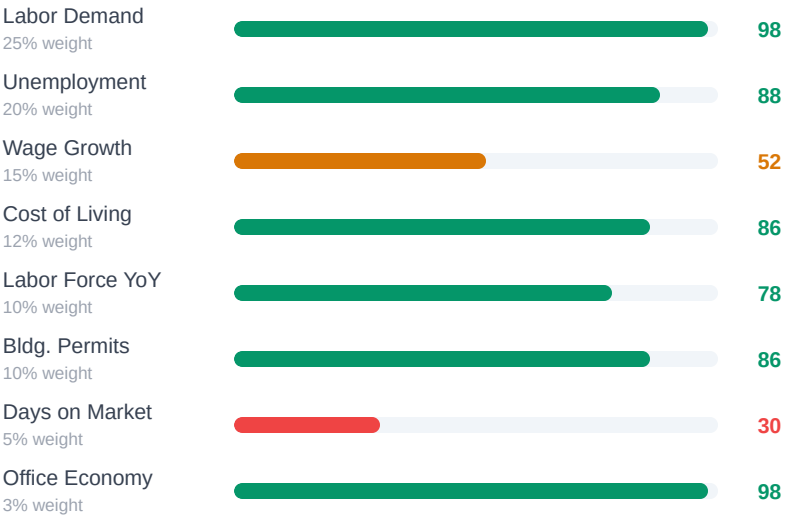
A+

EXCELLENT

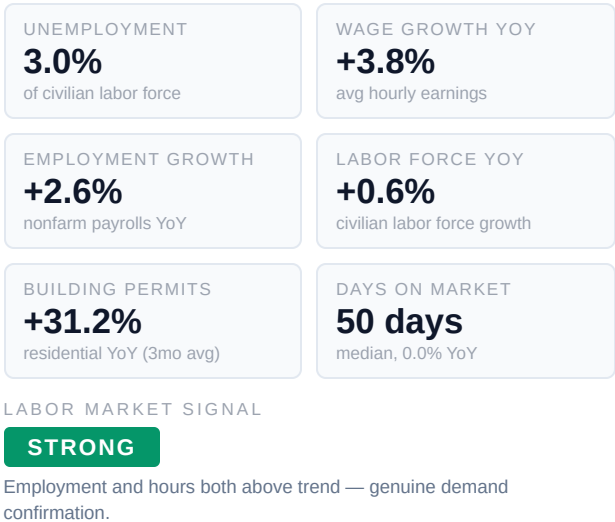
81.0th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 81.0th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 9.41, and its highly developed office economy, with a professional worker share of 4.54. The labor demand is driven by a 2.64% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.41% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.64% employment growth rate and a 1.41% increase in weekly hours above trend signals a genuine demand expansion in Raleigh-Cary, indicating that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation and hours worked. This suggests that businesses are actively hiring and workers are putting in more hours, which is a positive sign for the local economy. The high labor demand composite score of 9.41 further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.00%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, and wage pressure may be higher as a result. With an unemployment rate at the 88th percentile, the market has limited slack, making it essential for companies to offer competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Raleigh-Cary is 3.78%, which is near the median. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. While this may put some pressure on businesses, it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living percentile rank of 86th, indicating that it is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The city's PSF of \$218/sqft, which has decreased by 2.2% year-over-year, combined with an hourly earnings rate of \$37.84, results in a ratio of 5.76. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.58% year-over-year, which is above average. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city's workforce is increasing, providing a positive environment for hiring and business growth. As the labor force

grows, businesses may find it easier to find qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 31.25% year-over-year, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city's future housing supply is likely to increase, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Raleigh-Cary is 50 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. However, the stable days on market suggests that the city's housing market is not experiencing significant fluctuations.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a highly developed office economy, with a professional worker share of 4.54, ranking it at the 98th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less suited for industries with limited office-based roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a highly developed office economy, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the city's tight labor market and moderate wage growth rate may pose challenges for companies looking to hire and retain top talent, making it essential to factor in these constraints when making location decisions.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

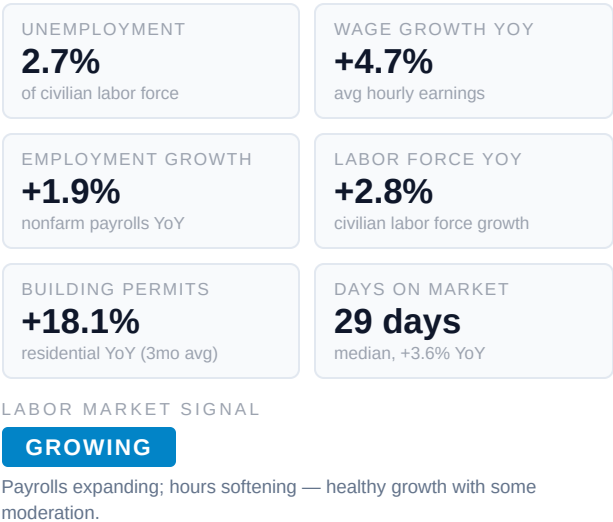
76.9th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 76.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.70% and its strong labor force growth of +2.77% year-over-year, indicating a tight and expanding labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.34, combining employment growth of +1.88% and a slight decline in weekly hours, suggests genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.88% and weekly hours deviation of -0.593% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while hours worked are slightly below trend. This combination signals that the labor market is growing, but not at an unsustainable pace. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 ranks in the top tier, at the 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is extremely low, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.73% is above average, ranking at the 62nd percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. Workers in the area are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Hartford is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 71, indicating that the city is more affordable than many of its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio of \$254/sqft to \$39.99/hr, or 6.35, is relatively low, and the fact that PSF is only rising by 0.8% year-over-year suggests that the city remains an attractive option for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, indicating an expanding labor pool. This growth suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a increasing number of workers available to fill open positions. The top-tier rank of 96th percentile for labor force growth reinforces this positive outlook.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +18.05%, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth suggests that the city is likely to see improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for workers in the future. The above-average rank of 78th percentile for building permits supports this positive trend.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.6%. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the market is competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges in finding available housing. The bottom-tier rank of 4th percentile for days on market indicates a very hot market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in the city is near the median, ranking at the 40th percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderate talent pool for tech, finance, and consulting businesses, but may not be as deep as in other cities. The city is likely well-suited for businesses that require a general professional workforce, but may not be the best fit for those requiring highly specialized talent.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely competitive housing market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find available and affordable housing, potentially impacting a business's ability to attract and retain talent.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

73.3th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		48
25% weight		
Unemployment		94
20% weight		
Wage Growth		88
15% weight		
Cost of Living		92
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		34
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		88
10% weight		
Days on Market		96
5% weight		
Office Economy		42
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.4% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +47.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 37 days median, +15.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.3th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.10% and strong wage growth of +6.37% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest that Cincinnati is an attractive location for businesses seeking a skilled workforce, but may pose challenges for hiring and talent retention.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +1.08% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.694% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.12, near the median. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as the city is adding jobs, albeit with slightly reduced hours. This scenario indicates a relatively stable labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.10%, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and wage pressure is likely to be high. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +6.37% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is beneficial for worker purchasing power, as employees' earnings are increasing rapidly. However, this may pose a challenge for businesses seeking to control labor costs.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a PSF of \$194/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.51, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This means that the city offers a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a relatively high standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums. The stable YoY change in PSF (+0.0%) also contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is contracting at a rate of -0.97% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is shrinking, posing a structural headwind for hiring and potentially limiting the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

Cincinnati is experiencing a significant increase in residential building permits, with a +47.86% year-over-year change, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This surge in permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and support workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cincinnati is 37 days, with a +15.6% year-over-year increase, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this trend may also suggest a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional talent pool is relatively shallow, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This suggests that the city is better suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, rather than tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely heavily on specialized office workers.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses seeking a skilled workforce. However, the city's shrinking labor force supply poses a significant risk, as it may limit the ability of businesses to hire and grow in the long term, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider this constraint when evaluating Cincinnati as a potential location.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A+

EXCELLENT

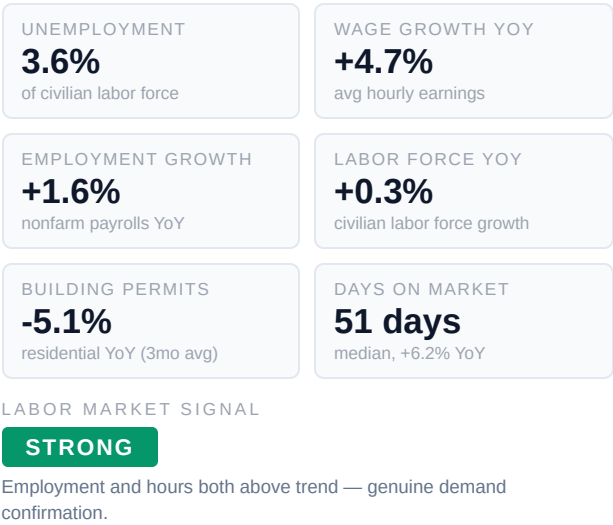
72.9th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 72.9th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 7.47, and its relatively low cost of living, with a ratio of \$221/sqft to \$38.03/hr, resulting in a top-tier percentile rank of 84th. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and attractive affordability.

Labor Demand

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has seen employment growth of +1.57% year-over-year, combined with a +0.970% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a strong increase in jobs, with hours worked also rising above trend, pointing to a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 7.47 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia stands at 3.60%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 70th. This rate indicates a relatively tight labor market, although not excessively so, suggesting that businesses may face some competition for talent but still have a manageable hiring environment. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this market is that it may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract the best candidates.

Wage Growth

Year-over-year wage growth in the Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area is +4.70%, placing it in the above-average category with a 60th percentile rank. This rate of wage growth is moderate, indicating that employer labor costs are rising but not at an alarming rate. For workers, this means increasing purchasing power, which can contribute to a stronger local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$221/sqft to \$38.03/hr and a year-over-year decrease of -1.3% in PSF, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia ranks in the top tier for affordability at the 84th percentile. This means the city is more affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without the need for significant wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has grown by +0.32% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. Although the growth rate is not robust, it suggests that the labor pool is not contracting, providing a stable foundation for

businesses looking to hire. This moderate growth implies that hiring capacity, while not unlimited, is supported by a gradually increasing labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -5.10%, signaling a tightening in housing supply. This decrease, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, may indicate future challenges in affordability and workforce accommodation, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could potentially impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.2%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as it may provide them with more time to find suitable housing. However, the market remains relatively competitive, and relocating workers should still be prepared to act fairly quickly.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia, combined with its growth trend, places it at an above-average percentile rank of 78th. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. The city is less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, given its stronger orientation towards knowledge-economy roles.

In conclusion, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia offers businesses a thriving labor market with strong demand, a relatively low cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for a variety of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decrease in building permits, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

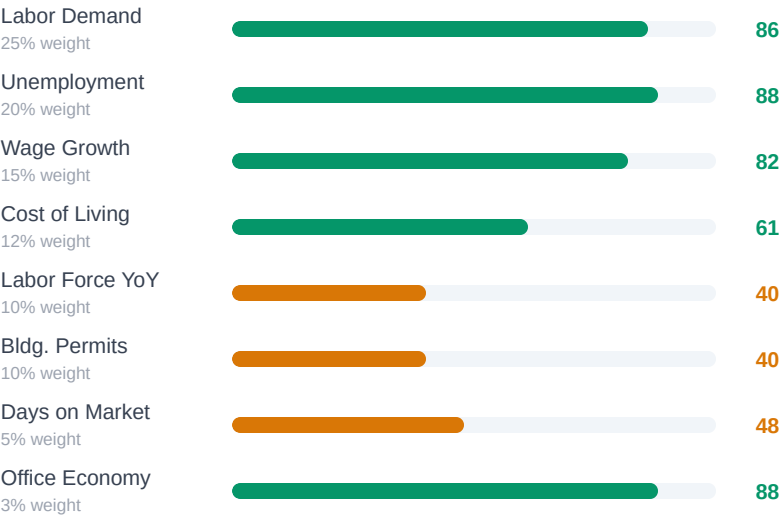
A+

EXCELLENT

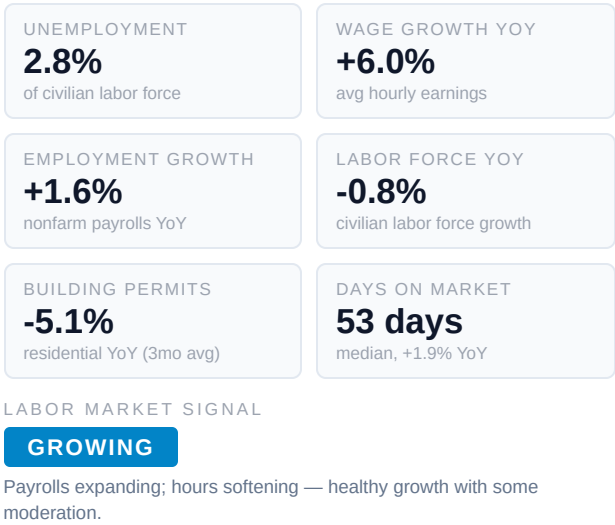
71.8th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 71.8th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with an 86th percentile ranking, and its low unemployment rate of 2.80%, which ranks in the 88th percentile. These metrics signal a strong and competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate is 1.56% year-over-year, and weekly hours are running 0.141% below trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the job market is growing and hours are not excessively stretched, indicating a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 2.80%, ranking in the 88th percentile. This low rate indicates a tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the city is 5.97%, ranking in the 82nd percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means workers have strong purchasing power. Businesses should factor in these increasing labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in the area.

Cost of Living

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has a cost of living score ranking in the 61st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$260/sqft to \$35.48/hr, or 7.33. Although not the most affordable, the city's relatively moderate cost of living, combined with a slight decline in PSF of 1.1% year-over-year, makes it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the city is shrinking at a rate of -0.82% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The city has experienced a -5.10% year-over-year change in residential building permits, also ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and

challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 53 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.9%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This relatively moderate pace of home sales indicates a competitive but still accessible market for relocating workers.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share ranks in the 88th percentile, indicating a deep and talented knowledge-economy pool. This makes Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics-based workforces.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers businesses a strong and competitive job market, with low unemployment and fast wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the tightening housing supply and potential future affordability concerns, which may impact the city's ability to attract and retain top talent.

Kansas City

Kansas City

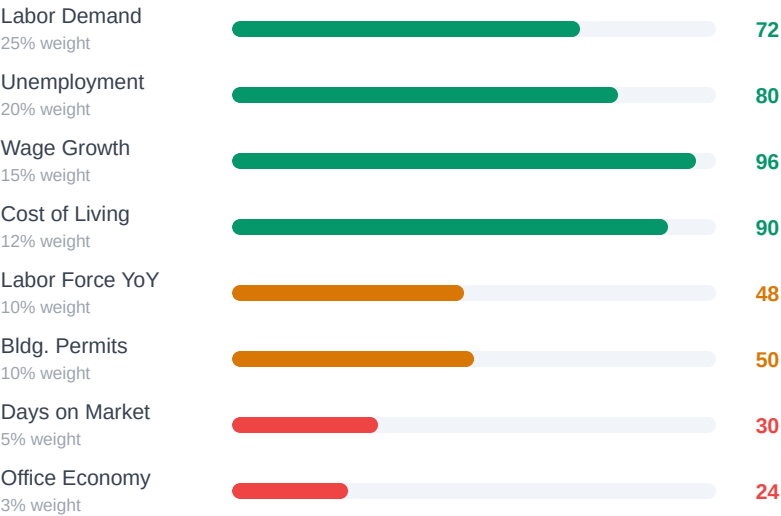
A+

EXCELLENT

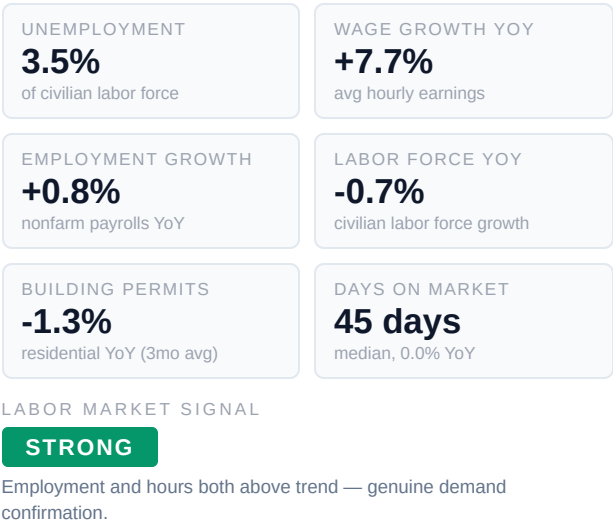
71.2th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking it at the 71.2th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its top-tier unemployment rate of 3.50% and exceptional wage growth of +7.70% year-over-year, indicating a highly competitive labor market. These metrics suggest a city with strong job market fundamentals, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate of +0.84% year-over-year, combined with a +0.296% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.77 further reinforces this notion, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.50% is notably low, ranking at the 80th percentile, which signifies a tight labor market with limited slack. For businesses, this means that hiring may be more challenging, and wage pressure could be higher due to the competitive nature of the job market. However, it also indicates a skilled and employed workforce, which can be beneficial for companies looking for talented workers.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +7.70%, Kansas City is experiencing rapid wage increases, ranking at the 96th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also suggests strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand. Businesses should be prepared for higher labor costs but can also expect a workforce with increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$197/sqft to \$35.67/hr, ranks at the 90th percentile in terms of affordability. This high percentile score indicates that the city is more affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without the need for significant wage premiums. The affordability of Kansas City can be a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is shrinking at a rate of -0.70% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply could pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -1.26%, indicating a slight tightening in housing supply. This decrease in permits, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile, suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation might be at risk if the trend continues. However, the current impact is relatively modest, and the city's overall affordability remains a strength.

Days on Market

Homes in Kansas City are currently sitting on the market for a median of 45 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 30th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which can be challenging for relocating workers. However, it also indicates a strong demand for housing, which can be beneficial for the local economy.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 24th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these sectors compared to other cities. This suggests that the city might be more suited for businesses outside of the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, which typically require a high concentration of professional workers. However, for companies in other industries, Kansas City's workforce could still offer significant advantages.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with low unemployment and strong wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking for skilled workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which could pose challenges for future hiring and workforce expansion. Despite this, the city's overall affordability, rapid wage growth, and strong job market fundamentals make it a compelling choice for businesses considering relocation or expansion.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A+

EXCELLENT

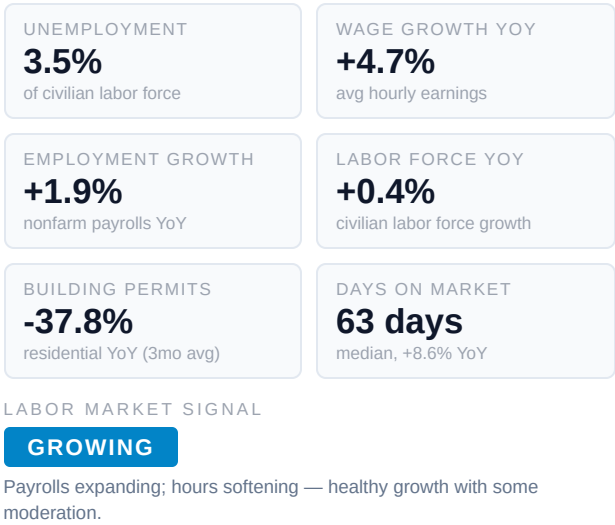
68.3th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.3th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 6.35, and its highly affordable cost of living, with a percentile rank of 96th. Specifically, the city's cost of living is characterized by a PSF of \$237/sqft, which has decreased by 8.1% YoY, and an hourly wage of \$37.55, resulting in a ratio of 6.31.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate is 1.89% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.596%. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while hours are slightly below trend, indicating a healthy and sustainable growth pace. The labor demand composite score of 6.35 further supports this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 3.50%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 68th. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, companies may face some wage pressure, but it is still manageable.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 4.74%, which is above average, ranking at the 64th percentile. This signals moderate to fast wage growth, implying rising labor costs for employers. However, it also translates to increased worker purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 96th, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is one of the most affordable cities relative to its peers. The decreasing PSF, down 8.1% YoY, and the relatively low PSF-to-earnings ratio of 6.31 make it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This affordability advantage can be a major draw for businesses looking to attract and retain employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.44% YoY, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is above average, ranking at the 74th percentile, it may not be sufficient to keep up with the city's job growth, potentially leading to some hiring challenges.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -37.80%, which is a sharp decline, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This signals a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased challenges for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 63 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.6%. This indicates a slowing market, making it slightly more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, with a percentile rank of 24th, the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite score of 4.22, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This makes Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, potentially offsetting some of the city's current advantages.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

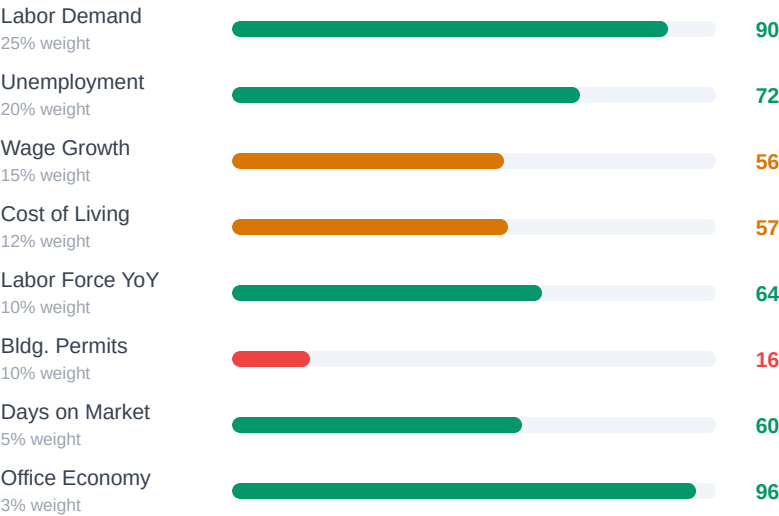
A

VERY GOOD

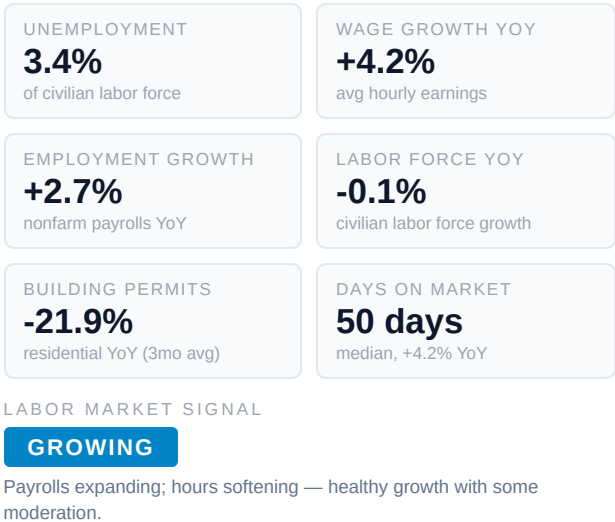
66.0th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, driven by a 90th percentile labor demand composite score and a 96th percentile office/professional worker share. The city's labor market is characterized by a 2.73% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.912% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a strong foundation for business growth.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a 2.73% year-over-year employment growth rate, combined with a -0.912% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This indicates that the city is adding jobs at a rapid pace, with hours worked being slightly below trend, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 7.21 places the city in the top tier, at the 90th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.40%, which is at the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The city has experienced a 4.19% year-over-year wage growth rate, placing it near the median at the 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing. While this is not exceptionally high, it still indicates a positive trend for workers and a potential cost consideration for businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$266/sqft to \$38.98/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.82, Salt Lake City-Murray ranks at the 57th percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking indicates that the city is neither exceptionally affordable nor expensive compared to its peers. The relatively stable cost of living means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but it also does not provide a strong competitive advantage in terms of affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown at a -0.06% year-over-year rate, placing it at the 64th percentile. This slight contraction in the labor force supply suggests that hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may face challenges in finding available

workers. However, the small negative growth rate indicates that this is not a significant constraint at present.

Building Permits

The city has seen a -21.89% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend may signal potential risks for businesses relying on a mobile workforce or looking to expand their operations.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 50 days, with a 4.2% year-over-year increase. This indicates a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling exceptionally quickly. The rising days on market, despite a strong job market, may suggest a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 4.40, placing it at the 96th percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep and talented professional pool. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a knowledgeable and skilled workforce.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, a deep professional talent pool, and a relatively stable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in residential building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This consideration should be factored into any business location decision to ensure long-term viability and success in the area.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

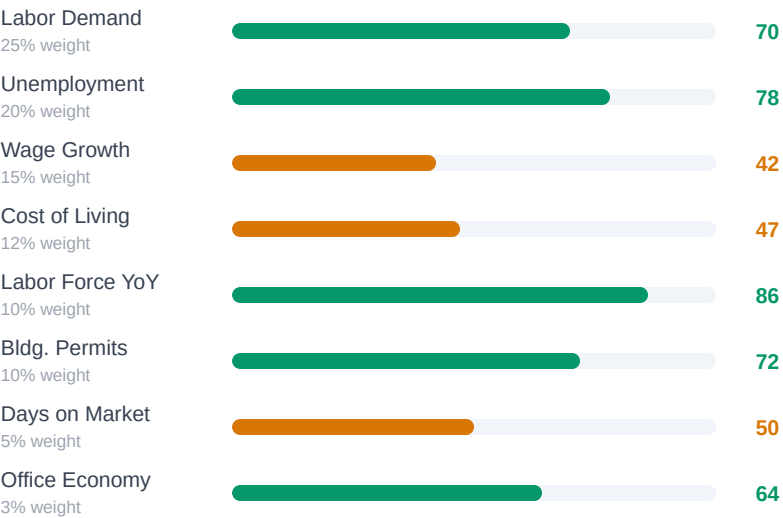
A

VERY GOOD

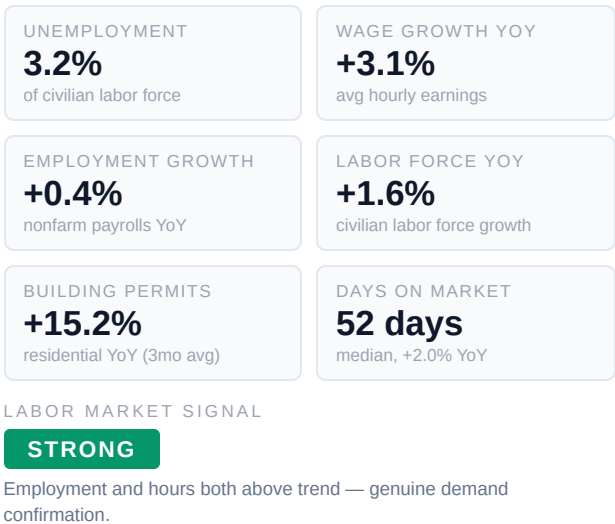
65.3th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate defining its current economic character, at 70th and 78th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 5.66, driven by a +0.41% employment growth rate and +0.789% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a growing economy and increasing labor needs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.41% and weekly hours deviation of +0.789% from trend indicate a labor market with genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This signals that the city is experiencing an increase in labor needs, driven by expanding businesses and industries. The labor demand composite score of 5.66, at the 70th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.20% is relatively low, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which can drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.15% is near the median, ranking in the 42nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers are experiencing some increase in purchasing power. The moderate wage growth rate may help balance the needs of businesses and workers in the city.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Atlanta, with a PSF of \$198/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.39, ranks in the 47th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive, relative to peers, and may not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums. The stable PSF-to-earnings ratio, with a 0.0% year-over-year change, suggests that affordability is not significantly improving or deteriorating.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.58% year-over-year, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a increasing pool of available workers, which can support business expansion and growth. The growing labor force also indicates a dynamic and attractive labor market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +15.16%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This growth suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city is likely to experience improving affordability and increased accommodation options for the workforce in the future. The rising permits also signal a reduction in the risk of a supply squeeze, which can constrain workforce growth.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 52 days, with a +2.0% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 50th percentile, indicating a near-median market speed. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor accessible, for workers relocating to the city. The slow increase in days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.06, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy talent, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant needs.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with growing demand, a tight unemployment environment, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to expand or establish operations. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for increasing labor costs and competition for talent, driven by the low unemployment rate and growing labor needs, which may require businesses to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract and retain workers.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

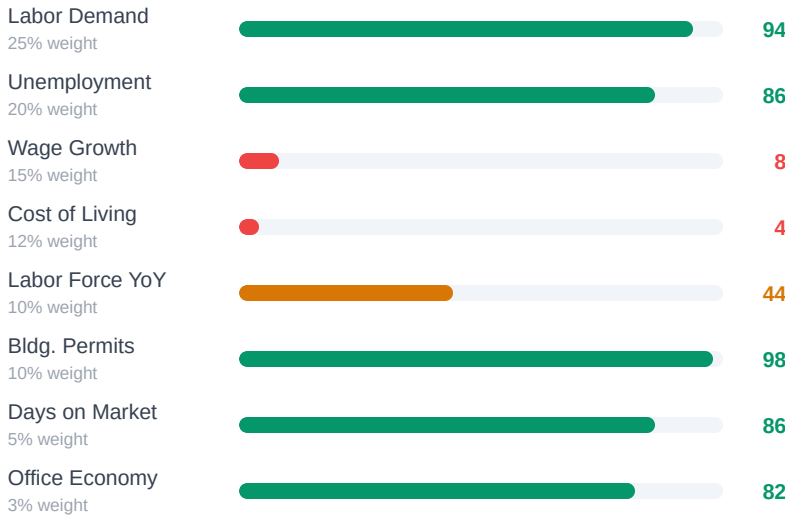
A

VERY GOOD

63.3th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.5%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.4%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.8%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+132.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

37 days

median, +8.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.3th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its exceptional labor demand and building permits growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.69, combining a 1.44% employment growth rate and a 1.369% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with a top-tier ranking in building permits growth, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is experiencing a labor demand expansion, with a 1.44% employment growth rate and weekly hours 1.369% above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand, as hours are increasing during a period of job growth, indicating that new jobs are being added and existing workers are taking on more hours. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 3.50%, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. As a result, wage pressure is likely to be higher in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 0.27%, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers may have limited bargaining power and purchasing power may not be increasing significantly. This could impact the local consumer demand and overall economic vitality.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living score ranking in the 4th percentile, with a PSF of \$813/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$53.33/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.24. The fact that PSF is falling by 4.9% YoY is a key driver of the low affordability score, indicating that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may offset the attractiveness of the area's strong labor market.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is shrinking at a rate of -0.76% year-over-year, ranking near the median. This contraction in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may

need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs to address this challenge.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has increased by 132.71% year-over-year, ranking in the 98th percentile. This rapid growth in building permits signals an expansion in housing supply, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find housing in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 37 days, with an 8.8% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 86th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market, but the rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization. For workers relocating to the area, this means that the housing market may be slightly more accessible than in the past, but it is still relatively fast-paced.

Office Economy

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 82nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on a highly skilled and specialized workforce. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, expanding housing supply, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech and finance sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain top talent, and the shrinking labor force supply, which could pose challenges for hiring and workforce development.

St. Louis

St. Louis

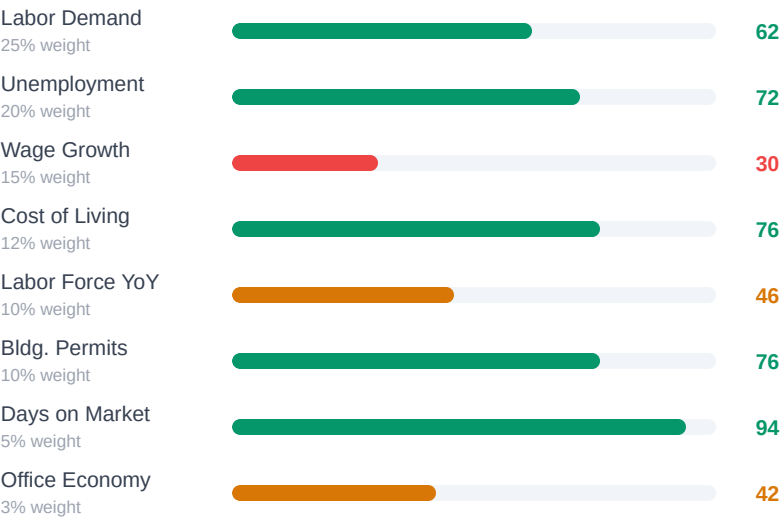
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GOOD

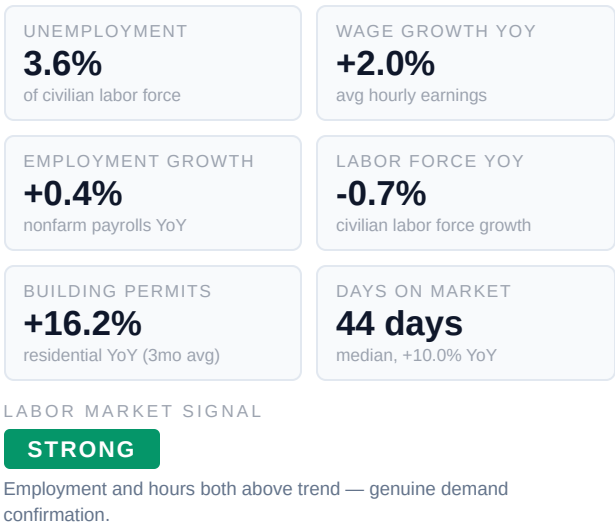
61.6th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 61.6th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.59, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 76th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand is driven by a 0.44% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.672% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 0.44% employment growth rate and a 0.672% increase in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion in St. Louis, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours. This suggests a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.59 further reinforces this notion, ranking the city above average.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis stands at 3.60%, which is above average, ranking at the 72nd percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, the practical implication is that businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

St. Louis has experienced a year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.03%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit gradually. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ranked at the 76th percentile, St. Louis is more affordable relative to its peers. The city's PSF of \$164/sqft, which has decreased by 1.2% year-over-year, combined with an average hourly earnings of \$37.27, results in a ratio of 4.40. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis has contracted by 0.72% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to accommodate this trend.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 16.20% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth suggests that developer confidence is high, and future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve. As a result, St. Louis may become a more attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in St. Louis is 44 days, with a 10.0% year-over-year increase. This slower market, ranked at the 94th percentile, indicates that homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to the city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional talent pool ranked at the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderately deep pool of specialized workers. The city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy, but may not be the ideal location for those requiring a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce, such as tech or finance companies.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand, affordable cost of living, and expanding housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool, which may require businesses to adapt their hiring strategies to accommodate this trend. Overall, St. Louis presents an attractive location for businesses looking to balance growth, affordability, and talent attraction.

Memphis

Memphis

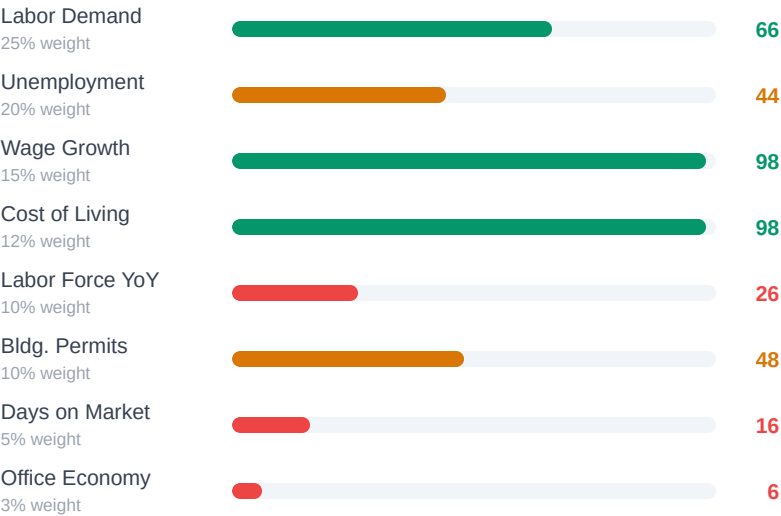
A-

GOOD

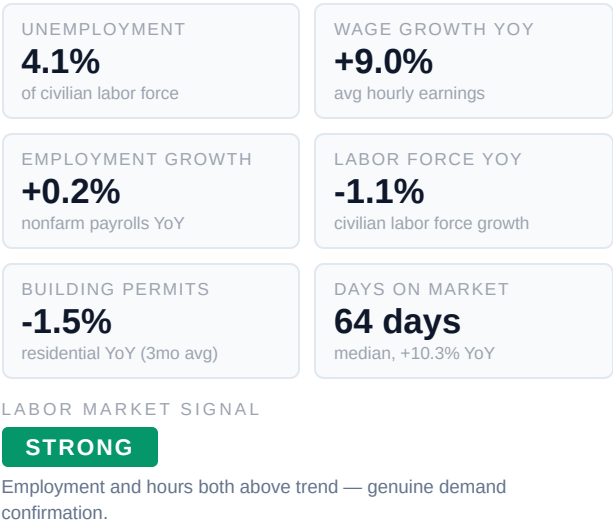
60.1th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 60.1th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally high wage growth rate of 9.02% year-over-year and its top-tier cost of living score, with a PSF to wages ratio of 4.61, driven by a 6.1% year-over-year decrease in PSF to \$155/sqft. These metrics suggest a city with strong labor market dynamics and an attractive affordability profile.

Labor Demand

Memphis exhibits a labor demand composite score of 5.65, ranking it above average at the 66th percentile, driven by employment growth of 0.22% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.041% above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The city's labor market is thus characterized by a genuine increase in labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis stands at 4.10%, placing it near the median at the 44th percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. For a business trying to hire in Memphis, this means there is a more manageable pool of potential candidates, reducing the pressure on wages compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 9.02%, Memphis ranks in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also enhances worker purchasing power. Businesses locating in Memphis should anticipate a competitive labor cost environment, driven by the strong growth in hourly earnings.

Cost of Living

Memphis offers a highly affordable cost of living, with a percentile rank of 98th, driven by a PSF to wages ratio of 4.61 and a year-over-year decrease of 6.1% in PSF to \$155/sqft. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without necessitating wage premiums from employers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is contracting at a rate of -1.15% year-over-year, ranking it below average at the 26th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking. Businesses may face challenges in finding sufficient talent to meet their needs.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Memphis have decreased by 1.49% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 48th percentile. This slight decline in permits suggests that housing supply is not expanding significantly, which could lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

Homes in Memphis are currently sitting on the market for a median of 64 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%. This indicates a slower market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. For workers relocating to Memphis, this slower pace could make it easier to find and secure housing, as the market is less competitive.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but potentially more suitable for industries with different skill requirements, like logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an attractive combination of high wage growth, affordable cost of living, and a labor market with some slack, making it an appealing location for certain types of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force, which poses a challenge for hiring and talent acquisition, potentially limiting the city's long-term growth prospects.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

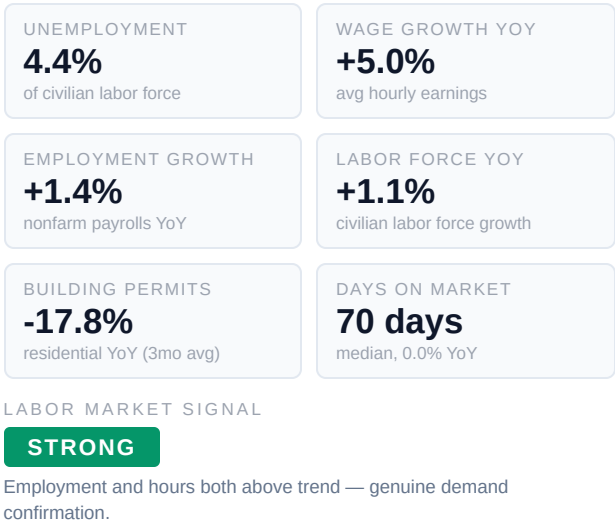
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.4th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 56.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, and its high share of office and professional workers, ranking at the 92nd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 1.39% year-over-year, combined with a 0.025% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 6.27 reflects this strong job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 4.40%, ranking at the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing extreme wage pressure. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

Wages in the Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area have grown by 5.04% year-over-year, ranking at the 66th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also indicates good worker purchasing power. As wages continue to grow, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score ranking at the 78th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$224/sqft to \$33.41/hr, or 6.70. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.0% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has grown by 1.11% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is strong, with a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has decreased by 17.79% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in permits signals potential future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply

of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 70 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market means that relocating workers may face competition for available homes, potentially making it more challenging for businesses to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep professional talent pool, with an office and professional worker share ranking at the 92nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries with primarily industrial or logistics roles.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential future affordability issue and workforce accommodation challenge posed by the sharp decline in building permits, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent over time.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

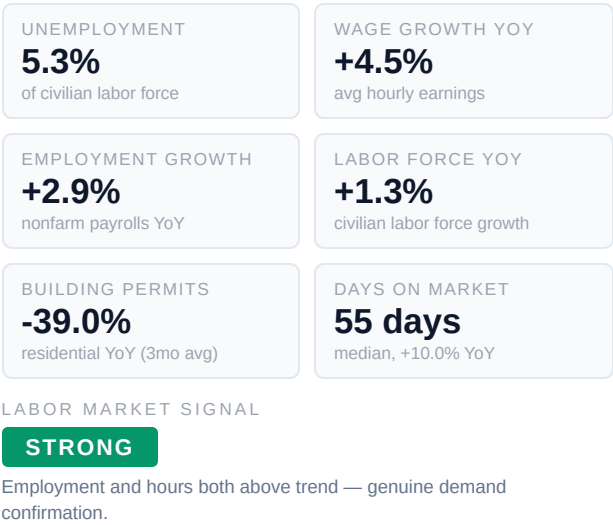
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.1th percentile
Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 56.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with a composite score of 8.57, and its strong labor force growth, at +1.33% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics signals a city with genuine demand expansion and a growing workforce.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has seen employment growth of +2.93% year-over-year, combined with a +0.171% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This indicates a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas stands at 5.30%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This suggests a relatively loose labor market, with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in the area has been +4.53% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. This balance could support both business operations and worker well-being.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$264/sqft to \$33.03/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of -1.9% in PSF, Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas ranks near the median in terms of affordability, at the 55th percentile. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without necessitating significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has grown by +1.33% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a structural advantage for hiring, as the labor pool is increasing.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits has been -38.98%, signaling a sharp contraction in housing supply expansion. This decline suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping

pace with demand.

Days on Market

Homes in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas currently sit on the market for a median of 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing, compared to faster-moving markets.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is significant, ranking it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, but less ideal for industries requiring large industrial or logistics workforces.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and growing workforce supply, making it an attractive location for expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
56.0th percentile
Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		26
Unemployment 20% weight		64
Wage Growth 15% weight		74
Cost of Living 12% weight		63
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		92
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		66
Days on Market 5% weight		22
Office Economy 3% weight		36

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +2.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +13.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 47 days median, -2.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 56.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth, at +1.99% year-over-year, and its above-average wage growth, at +5.61% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with an expanding workforce and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is +0.06% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation is -0.272% below its own trend. This combination signals a labor demand environment that is not expanding genuinely, as hours are below trend despite modest job growth. This may indicate some level of survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.80%, ranking it at the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure to attract and retain talent. In practical terms, companies looking to staff up in Pittsburgh may need to offer competitive salaries to stand out.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.61%, Pittsburgh is experiencing relatively fast wage growth, ranking it at the 74th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also means workers have increasing purchasing power. Businesses should factor in these higher labor costs when considering operations in Pittsburgh.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of \$174/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.99/hr, results in a ratio of 5.27, ranking it at the 63rd percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums. The modest increase in PSF (+0.6% YoY) suggests that affordability is not significantly eroding.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of +1.99% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that hiring capacity should not be constrained by a lack of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Pittsburgh are increasing by +13.14% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits is a positive indicator for future affordability and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce, suggesting that the city is likely to remain attractive to workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

Homes in Pittsburgh are currently sitting on the market for a median of 47 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.1%. This relatively fast market suggests that relocating workers may face a competitive environment when looking for housing, potentially affecting their decision to move to the area.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks at the 36th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these sectors compared to other cities. This suggests that Pittsburgh is less suited for businesses requiring a large pool of tech, finance, or consulting talent but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the tight labor market, which may lead to higher wage pressures and challenges in attracting the right talent, particularly in professional and office sectors.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B

AVERAGE

52.6th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		78
25% weight		
Unemployment		36
20% weight		
Wage Growth		26
15% weight		
Cost of Living		69
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		70
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		14
10% weight		
Days on Market		52
5% weight		
Office Economy		90
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.0% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -22.3% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 51 days median, +2.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.24, combining a 1.27% employment growth rate and a 0.162% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its cost of living, with a PSF of \$202/sqft and an hourly wage of \$37.13, resulting in a ratio of 5.44, ranks in the 69th percentile for affordability.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area exhibits a labor demand composite score of 6.24, driven by a 1.27% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.162% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a healthy and growing economy. The above-average labor demand score of 78th percentile further reinforces this positive outlook.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington stands at 4.00%, ranking in the 36th percentile, which indicates a below-average level of unemployment. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that the city has a strong job market, but it also poses a challenge for companies looking to expand their workforce.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 1.95%, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating below-average wage growth. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may help keep costs under control for businesses, it also means that workers may not see significant increases in their purchasing power, potentially affecting consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a cost of living score that ranks in the 69th percentile, with a PSF of \$202/sqft and an hourly wage of \$37.13, resulting in a ratio of 5.44. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 2.4% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of 0.19% year-over-year, ranking in the 70th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force provides a larger pool of potential employees, reducing the risk of labor shortages and making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has decreased by 22.31% year-over-year, ranking in the 14th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in permits may indicate a potential supply squeeze, making it essential for businesses to consider the long-term implications of this trend on their operations and employee relocation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%. This near-median ranking of 52nd percentile indicates a relatively balanced market. For workers relocating to this city, the current market conditions suggest a moderate level of competition, neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 4.06, ranking in the 90th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city's strong office economy is well-suited for knowledge-based industries, but it may be less suitable for companies primarily involved in industrial or logistics operations.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand, relatively low unemployment, and an affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future housing supply constraints and affordability issues, potentially affecting the city's attractiveness for relocating workers and the overall competitiveness of businesses operating in the area.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

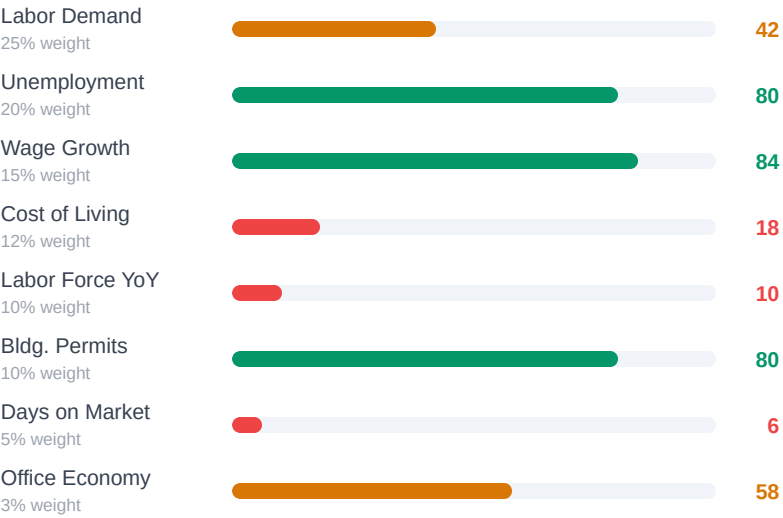
B

AVERAGE

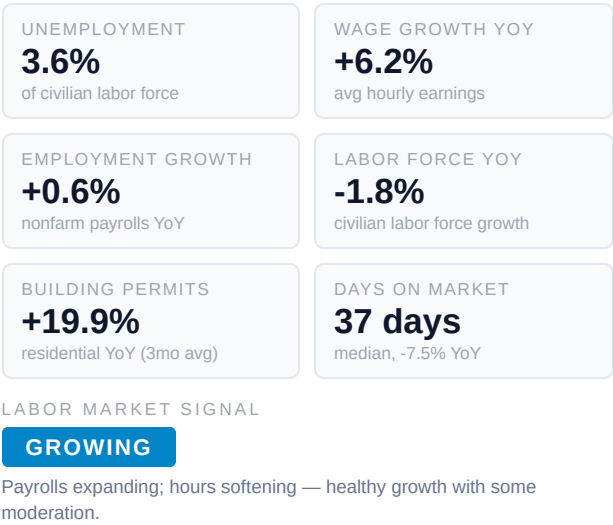
52.3th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 52.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong unemployment rate of 3.60% and high wage growth of 6.15%. These two metrics define the city's current economic character, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. The labor demand composite score of 4.92, although near median, suggests a more nuanced economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.60% and weekly hours deviation of -0.223% from the city's own trend suggest a moderate labor demand expansion, indicating genuine demand for labor rather than a survivor squeeze. This combination signals a growing economy, albeit with some constraints on labor supply. The near-median percentile rank of 42nd suggests a balanced labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.60% indicates a tight labor market, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure and competition for talent. In practical terms, companies may need to offer higher salaries or more attractive benefits to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.15% is relatively high, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, while also benefiting from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$649/sqft and an earnings ratio of 12.95, ranks in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive environment. However, the -4.1% YoY change in PSF suggests some improvement in affordability. This means that talent attraction may be challenging without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.81% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This suggests a shrinking labor pool, which may pose structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. Companies may need to consider strategies to attract talent from outside the area or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +19.88%, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This indicates an expanding housing supply, which may improve affordability and accommodation options for the workforce. As a result, businesses may benefit from a more stable and attractive environment for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 37 days, with a -7.5% year-over-year change, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This suggests a highly competitive housing market, which may pose challenges for relocating workers. However, the decreasing days on market may indicate a normalization of the market, making it slightly more accessible for newcomers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.88, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and affluent workforce, with a strong economy and expanding housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and high cost of living, which may require significant investments in talent attraction and retention strategies to remain competitive.

Columbus

Columbus

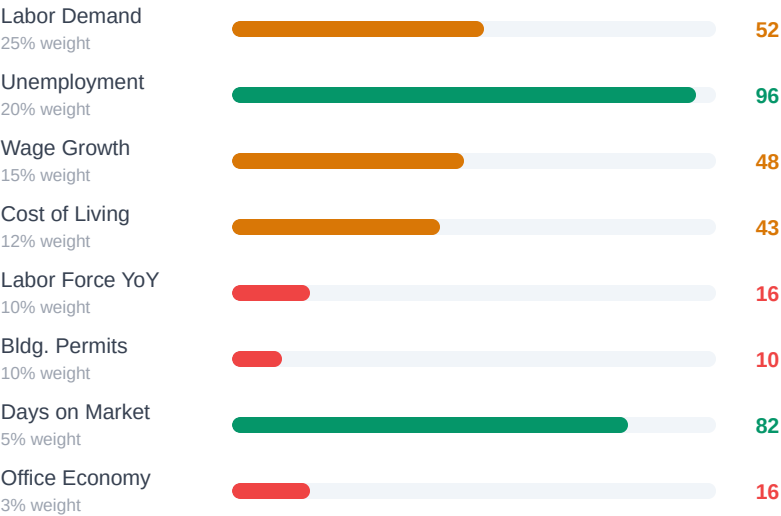
B

AVERAGE

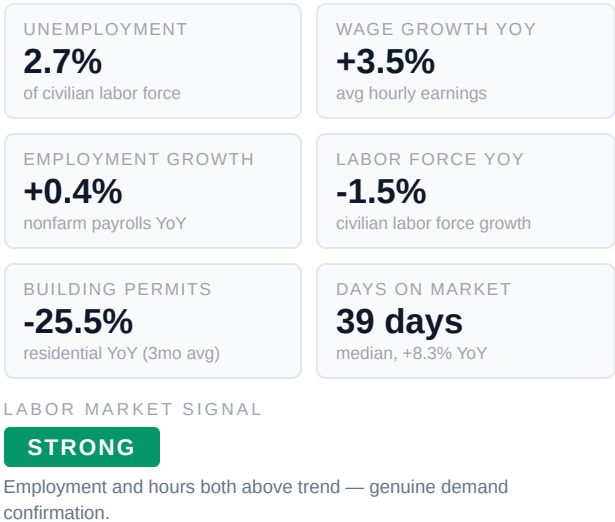
51.7th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 51.7th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 2.70% and a labor demand composite score of 5.16, which places it near the median. The city's economic character is most defined by its tight labor market and moderate labor demand growth, with employment growing at a rate of 0.44% year-over-year. This combination of low unemployment and moderate labor demand suggests a competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.44% and weekly hours deviation of 0.246% above trend indicate a moderate expansion of labor demand, signaling genuine demand for workers in the city. This combination suggests that businesses are adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, indicating a healthy labor market. However, the near-median percentile rank of 52nd suggests that this growth is not exceptionally strong compared to other cities.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is extremely low, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring and retaining workers, as the pool of available labor is small. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 3.49% is moderate, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not exceptionally quickly. While this wage growth supports worker purchasing power, it may not be sufficient to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.06, based on \$208 per square foot and \$34.31 per hour, Columbus ranks near the median at the 43rd percentile, indicating a moderately affordable city. However, the 1.0% year-over-year increase in PSF suggests that affordability may be decreasing. A high cost of living percentile rank would indicate greater affordability, but in this case, the city's rank suggests that it may not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.50% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -25.53%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 39 days, with an 8.3% year-over-year increase, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This suggests a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 1.40, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, Columbus has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as tech or finance companies.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a business a competitive labor market with moderate labor demand growth, but also presents challenges in terms of hiring and retaining workers due to its tight labor market. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's declining labor force supply, which may limit the availability of workers and drive up labor costs.

Birmingham

Birmingham

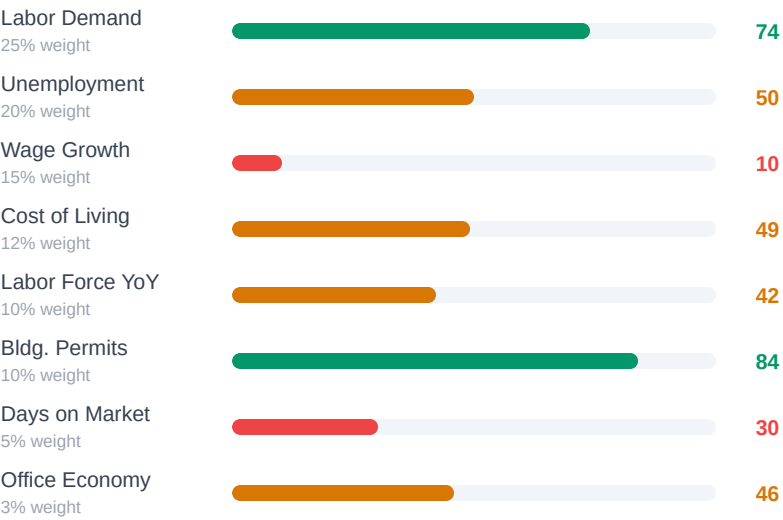
B

AVERAGE

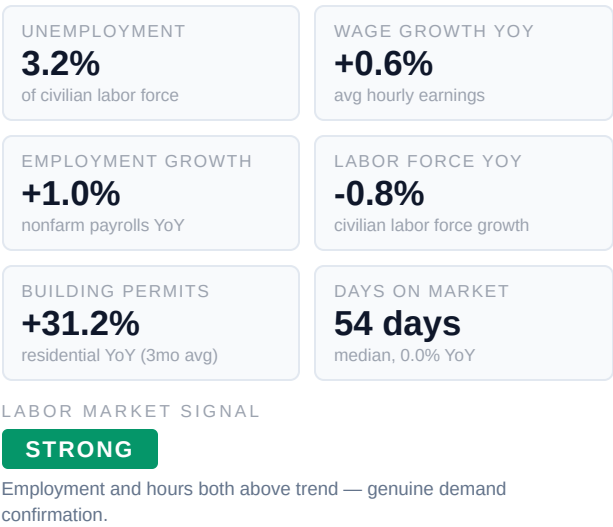
51.4th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 51.4th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and top-tier building permit growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.82, driven by a 0.97% employment growth rate and a 0.164% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the 31.24% year-over-year increase in building permits suggests a strong developer confidence in the city's future.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of 0.97% and weekly hours deviation of 0.164% above its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours running above trend. This combination signals a healthy labor market where businesses can find the talent they need. The labor demand composite score of 5.82 ranks in the 74th percentile, further reinforcing the city's strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham stands at 3.20%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This rate suggests a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For businesses trying to hire in Birmingham, this means they can find qualified candidates without excessive wage pressure, but may still face some competition for top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 0.59%, Birmingham's wage growth is stagnant, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may enjoy stable labor costs, but workers may have limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$160/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.48, results in a ratio of 4.93, ranking near the median at the 49th percentile. The city's cost of living is relatively affordable, with the PSF decreasing by 1.8% year-over-year. This affordability makes Birmingham an attractive location for talent, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing significant premiums to account for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is contracting at a rate of -0.77% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates. However, the city's strong labor demand and affordable cost of living may help mitigate this issue.

Building Permits

Birmingham's residential building permits have increased by 31.24% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This significant growth in building permits signals an expansion of the city's housing supply, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Birmingham is 54 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 30th percentile, may pose challenges for relocating workers, as they may face competition for available homes. However, the stable days on market suggests a balanced housing market, neither too hot nor too cold.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at the 46th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and industrial skills, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized tech or finance talent.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand, top-tier building permit growth, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the city's stagnant wage growth and contracting labor force supply pose significant risks that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Birmingham as a potential location for their business.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

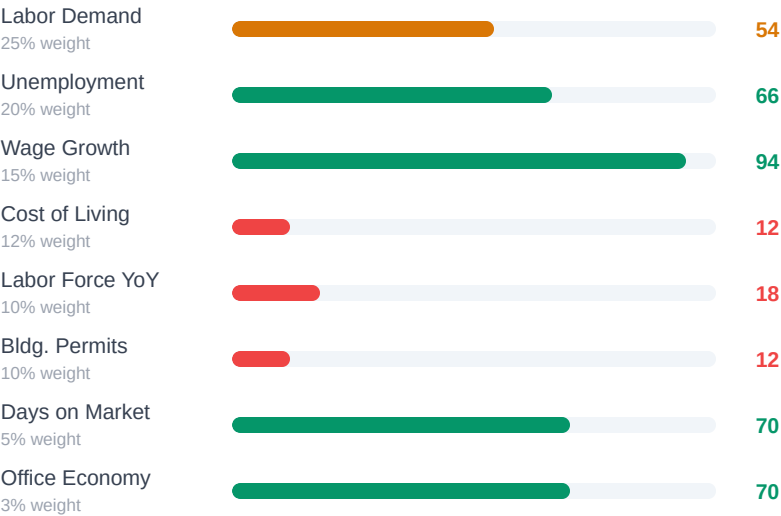
B

AVERAGE

50.9th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its high wage growth and low unemployment rate. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.20% year-over-year and an unemployment rate of 3.90%, which ranks in the 66th percentile. These metrics suggest a strong labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 1.07% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.558% from its own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.24, which ranks in the 54th percentile. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs but not excessively high. The negative hours deviation suggests some efficiency in labor utilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 3.90%, ranking in the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure to attract and retain talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.20%, ranking in the 94th percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, which could be a challenge for businesses with tight margins. However, it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score that ranks in the 12th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$604/sqft to \$43.09/hr, or 14.02. The city's PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year, which is a key driver of its relatively low affordability score. This suggests that the city is expensive relative to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is shrinking at a rate of -1.41% year-over-year, ranking in the 18th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies or offer more competitive compensation packages to attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has decreased by 23.29% year-over-year, ranking in the 12th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.9%, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market could also signal a normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has an office economy score that ranks in the 70th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with high wage growth and low unemployment, but also presents challenges such as a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

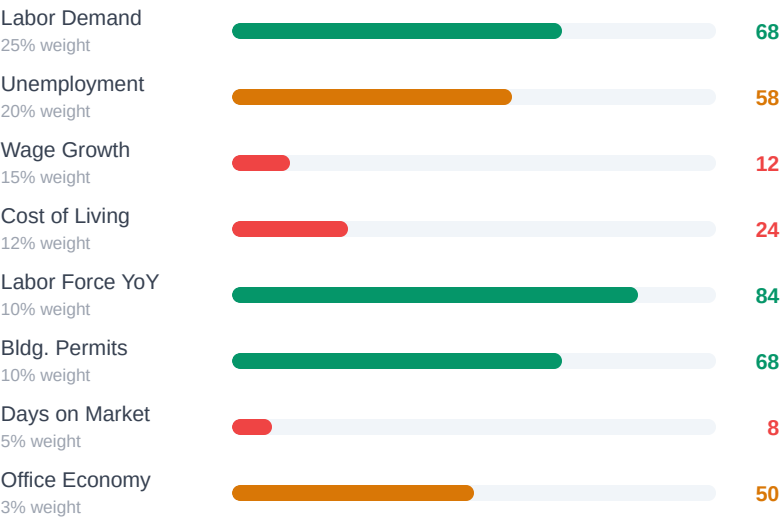
B

AVERAGE

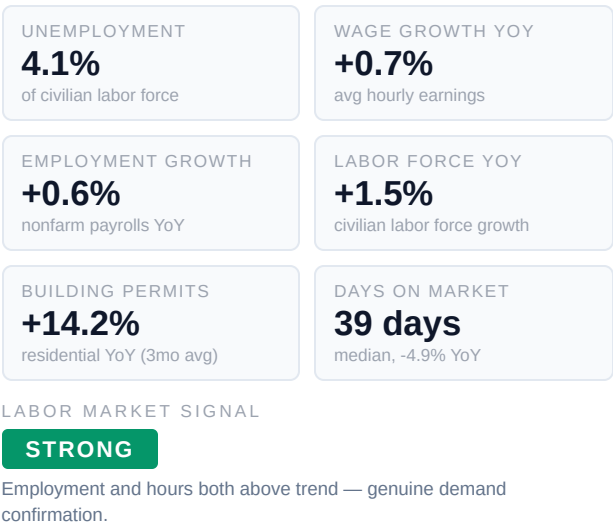
50.4th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and labor force growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.65, combining a +0.61% employment growth rate and a +0.496% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its labor force growth rate of +1.49% YoY indicates an expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.61% and weekly hours deviation of +0.496% signal genuine demand expansion, as both metrics are above their respective trends. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a genuine increase in labor demand, with more jobs being added and hours worked above the trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.65, ranking in the 68th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.10% places the city near the median, ranking in the 58th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent, which may lead to moderate wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.68% is relatively slow, ranking in the 12th percentile. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means weaker bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost increases, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$232/sqft and an earnings ratio of 7.13, ranks in the 24th percentile, indicating that it is less affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is decreasing by -0.4% YoY is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score suggests that the city may require wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.49% YoY, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth rate, ranking in the 84th percentile, suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a increasing number of workers available to fill job openings.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +14.19%, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This increase in permits, ranking in the 68th percentile, signals that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which may lead to better affordability and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 39 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.9%. This decrease, ranking in the 8th percentile, suggests a competitive market, where homes are selling relatively quickly. However, for a worker relocating to this city, the fast-paced market may make it challenging to find a home.

Office Economy

The city's office economy, with a professional worker share of 2.58, ranks near the median, in the 50th percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool, making it suitable for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional roles. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and labor force growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand their workforce. However, the city's relatively slow wage growth and less affordable cost of living may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, which is the single biggest risk or constraint that decision-makers should factor in when considering this location.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

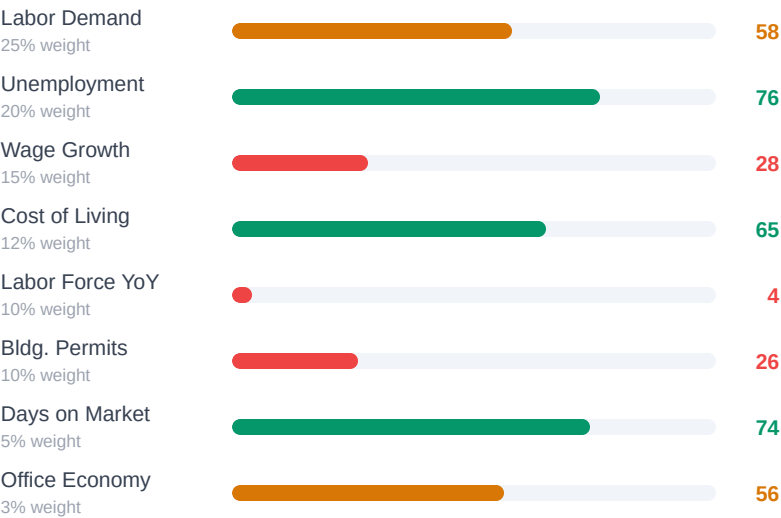
B

AVERAGE

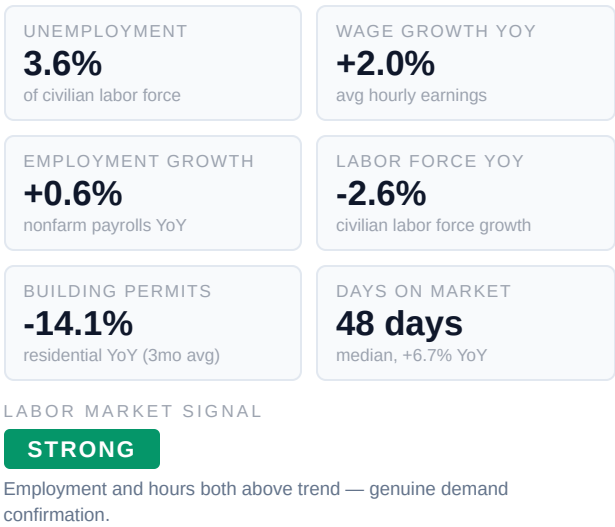
50.1th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and unemployment metrics. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.29, combining a +0.60% employment growth rate and a +0.147% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, suggests a near median performance. The unemployment rate of 3.60% also stands out, indicating a relatively tight labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.60% and weekly hours deviation of +0.147% from its own trend suggest genuine demand expansion in the Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area. This combination signals that the city is experiencing job growth with hours running above trend, indicating a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.29, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.60% in Denver-Aurora-Centennial indicates a tight labor market, ranking above average at the 76th percentile. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with potential upward pressure on wages. For a company trying to hire in this city, the low unemployment rate means a more competitive hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.01% in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. For workers, this means modest increases in purchasing power, but not as strong as in cities with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score that ranks above average at the 65th percentile, with a PSF of \$286/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.34/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.75. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.7% YoY relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it a competitive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is contracting at a rate of -2.58% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies or consider relocation to areas with expanding labor forces.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -14.11%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased housing costs and reduced attractiveness for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.7%. This increase, ranking above average at the 74th percentile, indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market could make it easier to find a home, but it also signals a less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a professional and office worker share that ranks near the median at the 56th percentile, with a composite score of 2.86. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but not as strong as in cities with higher rankings. The city is less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for companies seeking to minimize labor costs while still accessing a skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force, which poses significant challenges for future hiring and talent acquisition, potentially outweighing the city's current advantages.

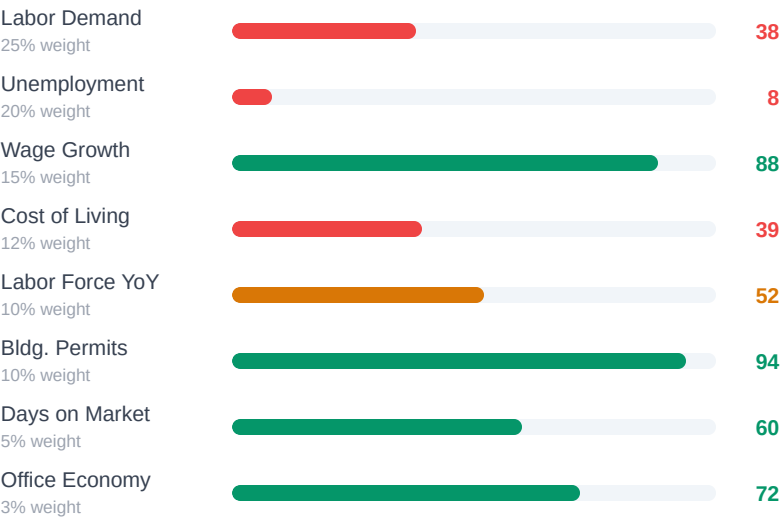
Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

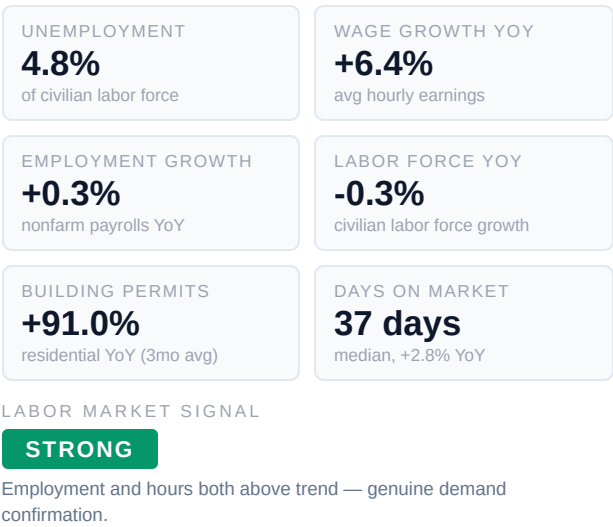
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.7th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 48.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.37%, and its high building permits growth, up 91.03% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy, but also with challenges in affordability and labor market tightness.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.27% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.048% above its own trend. This signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly more hours than usual. However, the labor demand composite score is below average, ranking at the 38th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 4.80%, which is relatively high and ranks at the 8th percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing extreme wage pressure. However, this also suggests weaker local consumer demand compared to cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 6.37%, which is relatively fast and ranks at the 88th percentile. This implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, while workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living ratio of \$444/sqft to \$47.26/hr, with the price per square foot falling 3.5% year-over-year. However, the city's affordability score is below average, ranking at the 39th percentile. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living could be a deterrent for some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is shrinking at a rate of -0.29% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This indicates a contracting labor pool, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the city. As the labor force shrinks, businesses may face increasing competition for a smaller pool of workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has increased by 91.03% year-over-year, ranking at the 94th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding rapidly, which may improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. As new housing units come online, the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.8%. This ranks at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to attract workers.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking at the 72nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a growing economy with a strong talent pool and expanding housing supply, but also poses challenges in terms of affordability and labor market tightness. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, and could potentially limit the city's appeal to some businesses and workers.

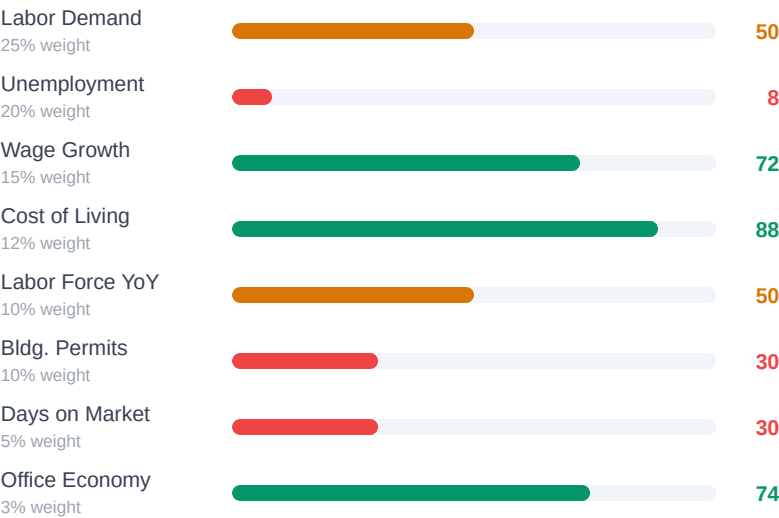
Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

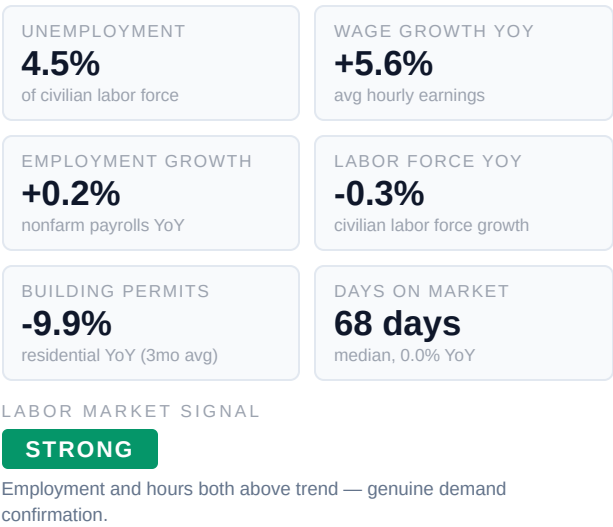
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.2th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 47.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 5.58% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 4.50%, which signals a tight labor market. The cost of living, with a PSF of \$238/sqft and a ratio of 6.38 to hourly earnings of \$37.30, is also a key factor, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile for affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 0.23% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.504% above its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.13. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The hours above trend during job growth suggest that the existing workforce is being utilized more intensely, rather than just adding new jobs.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.50%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, which means the labor market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.58%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies that employer labor costs are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. The rapid wage growth may attract more workers to the area, but it also increases the cost of doing business.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of 6.38, with a PSF of \$238/sqft and hourly earnings of \$37.30, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile for affordability. This high affordability ranking means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring large wage premiums. The falling PSF, down 4.4% year-over-year, is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is shrinking at a rate of -0.30% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is not expanding. The shrinking labor force may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is falling at a rate of -9.95% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits signals that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and limit the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce. The falling permits imply that developer confidence is waning.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 68 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This relatively slow market means that homes are not selling quickly, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable days on market may also indicate a lack of urgency in the housing market.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth, low unemployment, and affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth and accommodate a growing workforce.

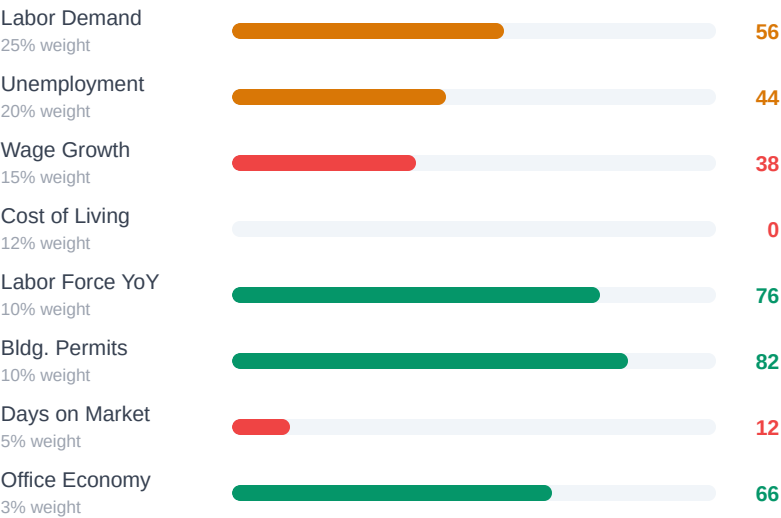
New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

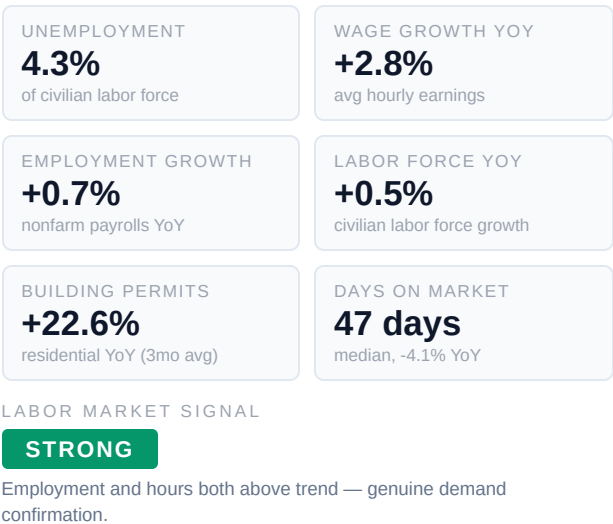
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.9th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 46.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its extremely low affordability, with a cost of living percentile rank of 0th percentile, and its strong labor force growth, at +0.45% YoY. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is +0.68% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.000%, indicating a near-stable labor demand environment. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one, with jobs being added and hours running slightly above trend. However, the labor demand composite score of 5.25 ranks only at the 56th percentile, suggesting that the demand is not exceptionally strong.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.30%, ranking at the 44th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it is also not overly loose, with some competition for talent still present. For a business trying to hire here, this means that they may face some challenges in attracting the right candidates, but it is still a manageable environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this metro area is +2.82%, ranking at the 38th percentile, indicating a below-average pace of wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a moderate pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the need to attract and retain talent in a competitive market.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is extremely high, with a PSF of \$537/sqft and an earnings ratio of 13.25, ranking at the 0th percentile. This means that the city is very expensive relative to peers, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by +3.3% YoY relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of +0.45% YoY, ranking at the 76th percentile, indicating an expanding labor force supply. This suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is increasing, with more workers available to fill open positions. However, the high cost of living may still pose a challenge in attracting and retaining talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in this metro area is increasing by +22.60% YoY, ranking at the 82nd percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the future affordability and workforce accommodation in the area may improve, as more housing options become available. However, the current cost of living remains a significant challenge.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 47 days, with a YoY decrease of -4.1%, ranking at the 12th percentile. This indicates a fast-paced and competitive housing market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The low percentile rank suggests that homes are selling quickly, and workers may face significant competition in the market.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in this metro area is 3.08, ranking at the 66th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy talent, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a strong and growing labor force, with an expanding housing supply and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely high cost of living, which may require significant wage premiums to attract and retain talent, posing a challenge for businesses looking to establish or expand operations in this area.

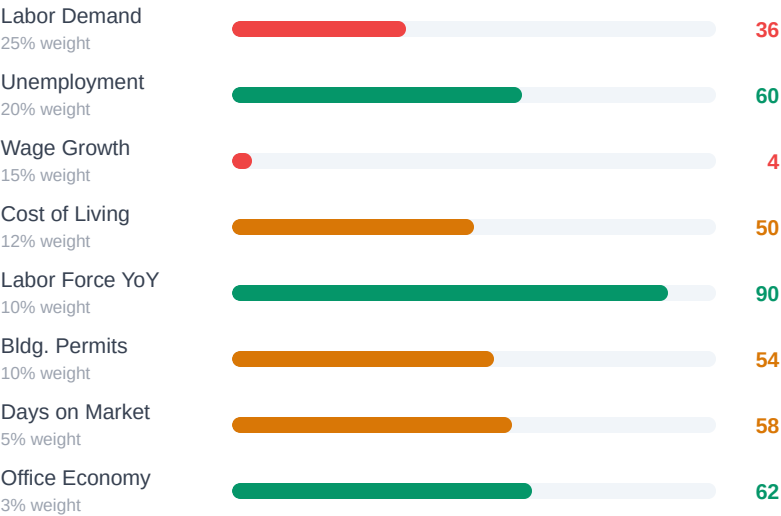
Cleveland

Cleveland

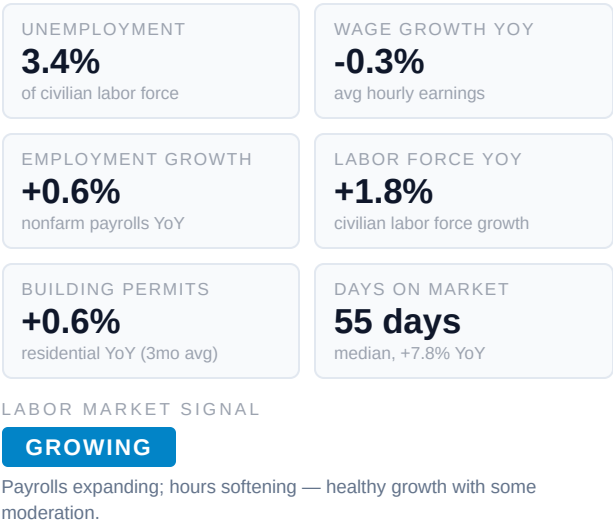
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.8th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.8th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is below average, and its labor force growth, which is in the top tier at 90th percentile with a 1.80% year-over-year increase. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 4.66 and the unemployment rate of 3.40% are key metrics that shape the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is 0.57% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is -0.437%, indicating a below-average labor demand. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, suggesting that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The negative hours deviation, in particular, points to a potential survivor squeeze, where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, which ranks in the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market implies that wage pressure is likely to be higher in Cleveland compared to cities with higher unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

Cleveland's year-over-year wage growth is -0.32%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers. The slow wage growth may make it challenging for businesses to attract and retain top talent, as workers may seek better compensation packages in other cities.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$143/sqft to \$33.82/hr, Cleveland's affordability score ranks near the median at the 50th percentile. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The 13.5% year-over-year increase in PSF, however, may erode affordability over time. As a result, businesses may not necessarily have a talent attraction advantage due to low costs, but they also do not face a significant disadvantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of 1.80% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. The increasing labor force can help alleviate hiring challenges and provide a more robust talent pipeline for companies.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Cleveland has increased by 0.56% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This modest growth in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, albeit slowly. While this expansion is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, the relatively slow pace of growth may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.8%. This ranks near the median at the 58th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced market. For workers relocating to Cleveland, the market is neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible, providing a moderate environment for finding housing.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional and office worker share ranks in the 62nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's economy is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers, but it may be less ideal for companies with primarily industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a relatively tight labor market, which can be both a blessing and a curse. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's stagnant wage growth, which may impact talent attraction and retention. Despite this challenge, Cleveland's expanding labor force and modestly growing housing supply make it an attractive location for businesses seeking to establish or expand operations in a city with a deep professional talent pool.

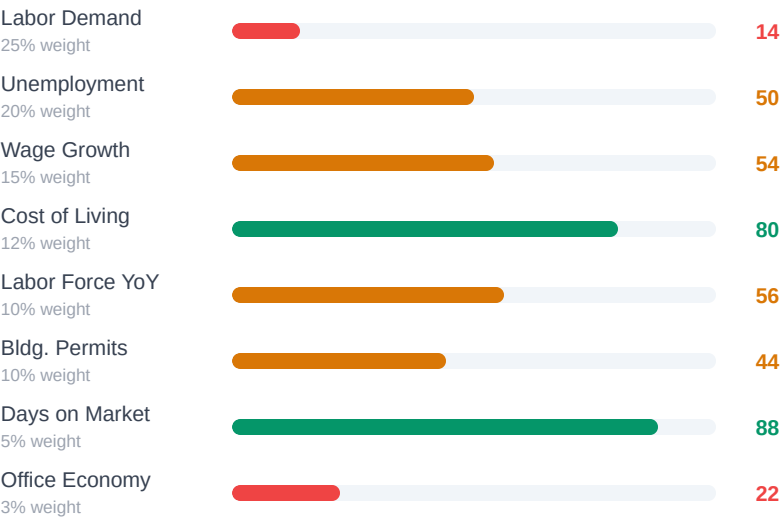
Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

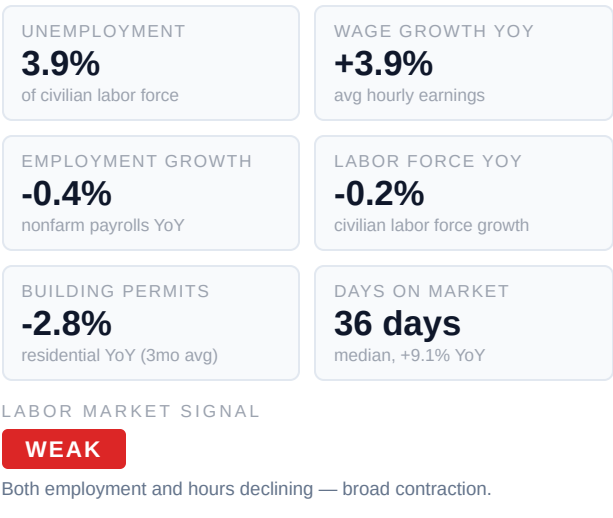
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.2th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, and its relatively high cost of living, which ranks in the 80th percentile for affordability. The combination of a -0.37% employment growth rate and a -0.648% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests a contracting labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.37% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.648% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. As a result, businesses may face a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 3.90%, which places it near the median at the 50th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that businesses may still face some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +3.93%, which is near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. Workers in the area will also experience an increase in purchasing power, which can benefit local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score that ranks in the 80th percentile for affordability, with a PSF of \$219/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.97/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.92. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.4% year-over-year contributes to the city's high affordability score. This makes the city more attractive for talent attraction, as workers can afford a higher quality of life without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of -0.22% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 56th percentile. This slight contraction in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract talent from a smaller labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is decreasing by -2.81% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 44th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could negatively impact the city's ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.1%. This places the city in the top tier at the 88th percentile for days on market, indicating a slower market where homes sit longer before being sold. For workers relocating to the city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, allowing them to find and purchase homes with relative ease.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is below average, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, making it less suited for businesses that rely heavily on these sectors. However, the city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate pace of wage growth, but its weak labor demand and tightening housing supply pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for businesses considering this location is the city's limited labor market growth and potential survivor squeeze, which may impact their ability to attract and retain talent in the long term.

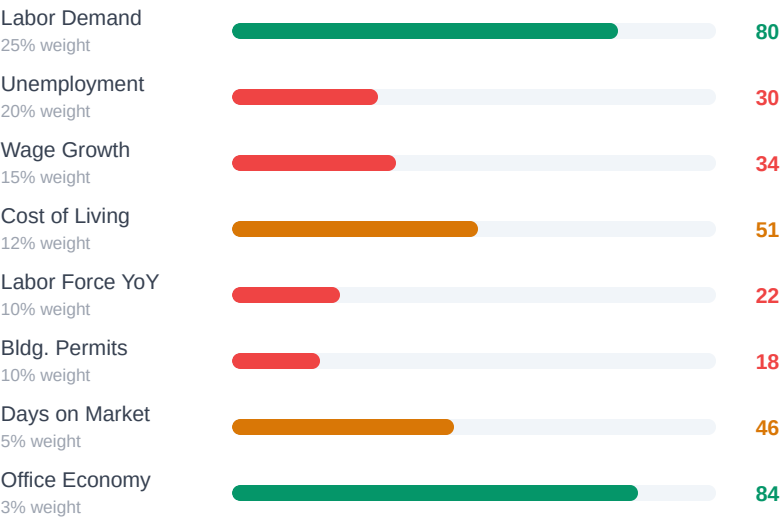
Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

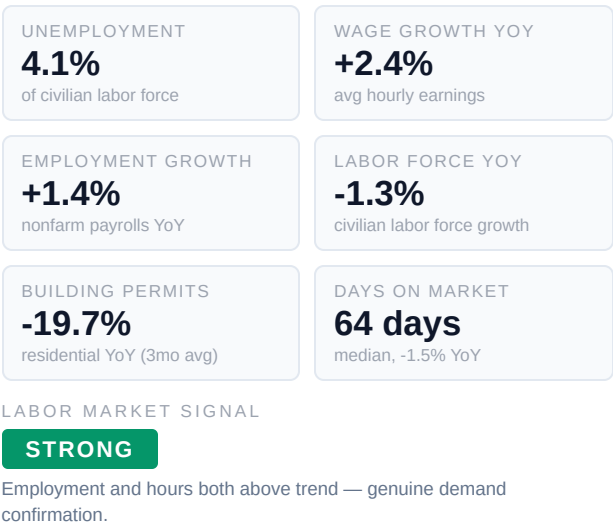
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.0th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 80th percentile, and its relatively high share of office and professional workers, ranking at the 84th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend.

Labor Demand

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has seen employment growth of 1.37% year-over-year, combined with a 0.048% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 6.27 further supports this, indicating a strong and growing job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.10%, ranking at the 30th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent. Businesses trying to hire in this market may face some wage pressure, but it is not as intense as in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has been moderate, with a year-over-year increase of 2.39% in hourly earnings, ranking at the 34th percentile. This rate of wage growth is not extremely high, but it still poses some upward pressure on labor costs for employers. At the same time, it supports worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$269/sqft to \$37.40/hr, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler ranks at the 51st percentile in terms of affordability, indicating a near-median level of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.8% year-over-year relative to wages suggests that the city is becoming more affordable. This can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has contracted by 1.31% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development to build the skills they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has decreased by 19.67% year-over-year, ranking at the 18th percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening of housing supply, which can lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area. This trend poses a risk to future workforce accommodation and affordability.

Days on Market

Homes in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler are currently sitting on the market for a median of 64 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.5%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The market is somewhat competitive, but the relatively short days on market suggest that it is still accessible for those looking to relocate.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking at the 84th percentile, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy roles, but may be less ideal for those with primarily industrial or logistics-dominant operations.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which poses a threat to future affordability and workforce accommodation, and may require businesses to consider strategies to attract and retain workers in a competitive market.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

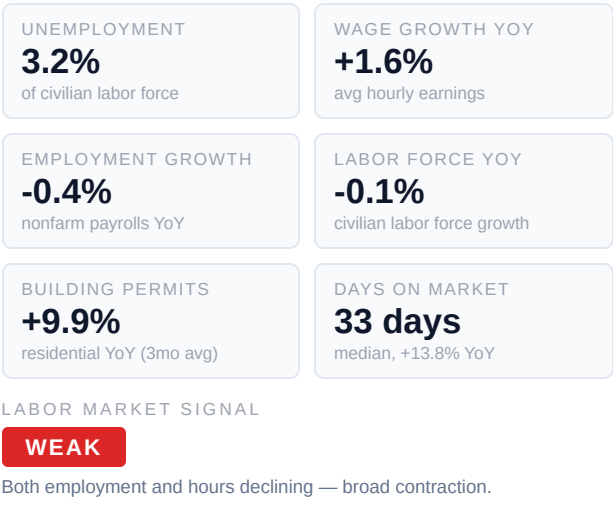
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.7th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.20% ranking in the top tier. The combination of these two metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.36% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.511% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with payrolls contracting and hours below trend. The labor demand composite score of 3.80 falls in the bottom tier, reinforcing this conclusion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.20%, which ranks in the top tier, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure. With a market this tight, hiring may be more difficult and expensive.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.56%, which is below average, ranking in the 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not strongly. This may lead to a relatively stable cost environment for businesses, but with limited bargaining power for workers.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score that ranks in the 20th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$230/sqft vs \$36.18/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.36, and PSF is rising 2.2% year-over-year. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively high.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor force supply. This implies that the hiring capacity for businesses may be limited, and the labor pool is not expanding rapidly. However, the 60th percentile rank suggests that this contraction is not as severe as in some other cities.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by 9.94% year-over-year, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve. The above-average rank of 64th percentile reinforces this positive outlook.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.8%, ranking in the top tier. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The high percentile rank of 92nd suggests that this market is particularly buyer-friendly.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 1.76, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but also a challenging environment for hiring and expansion due to low labor demand. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited labor force growth and the relatively high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract talent.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.4th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		60
Unemployment 20% weight		22
Wage Growth 15% weight		22
Cost of Living 12% weight		53
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		68
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		24
Days on Market 5% weight		76
Office Economy 3% weight		78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -14.7% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 50 days median, +8.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 44.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score at the 60th percentile, and its below-average unemployment rate, at 22nd percentile, indicating a tight labor market. The labor demand is driven by a 1.14% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.342% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.14% and the -0.342% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend signal a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running slightly below trend during a period of job growth. This combination indicates that the labor market is experiencing real growth, but the slight decrease in hours worked suggests that the growth might not be as robust as it seems. The labor demand composite score of 5.55 further supports this interpretation, ranking at the 60th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.60% is relatively high, ranking at the 22nd percentile, which means the labor market has some slack. However, this still presents a challenge for businesses trying to hire, as the market is not as loose as the unemployment rate might suggest, and wage pressure could be a concern. The practical implication for a business is that hiring might be somewhat easier than in tighter markets, but it's not an overly favorable environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.52% is below average, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth implies a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but it also means workers have weak bargaining power. For businesses, this could mean labor costs are not increasing rapidly, but it also suggests that worker purchasing power is not growing significantly.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.78, based on \$172/sqft (which is decreasing by 2.3% year-over-year) versus \$36.01/hr, Houston ranks at the 53rd percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. For talent attraction, this means that Houston does not have a significant advantage in terms of cost of living, as it does not offer exceptionally low costs without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.03% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses have a slightly increasing pool of potential workers to draw from, which could ease hiring challenges over time.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -14.66%, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This significant decrease in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend signals a potential risk for businesses relying on an expanding and affordable housing supply for their workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with an 8.7% year-over-year increase. This increase, ranking at the 76th percentile, indicates a slower market. For a worker relocating to this city, the slower market could make it easier to find a home, as properties are not being snapped up as quickly as in hotter markets.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 3.28, ranking at the 78th percentile, Houston has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but might be less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

In conclusion, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands offers a mix of above-average labor demand and a relatively slow wage growth environment, which could be attractive for businesses looking to manage labor costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decrease in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in attracting and retaining workers.

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

C+

POOR

43.1th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		76
Unemployment 20% weight		28
Wage Growth 15% weight		50
Cost of Living 12% weight		6
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		8
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		46
Days on Market 5% weight		68
Office Economy 3% weight		48

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.8% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.8% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -2.4% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 50 days median, +6.4% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 43.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 5.96 ranking it at the 76th percentile, and its cost of living, which is ranked at the 6th percentile due to a high PSF to wages ratio of \$662/sqft to \$41.35/hr. The labor demand and cost of living metrics provide a mixed picture of the city's economic health.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 1.83% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.906% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.96 confirms this, ranking the city at the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 4.80%, ranking it at the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 3.57%, ranking it at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has a cost of living ranked at the 6th percentile, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF to wages ratio of \$662/sqft to \$41.35/hr is high, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. However, the fact that PSF is falling -2.5% year-over-year provides some relief.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, ranking it at the 8th percentile. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is falling -2.43% year-over-year, ranking it at the 46th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.4%. This rising days on market indicates a slowing market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively fast pace of sales still poses some challenges for relocating workers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is ranked at the 48th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be the best fit for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a mix of genuine labor demand expansion and moderate wage growth, but also poses significant challenges due to its high cost of living and tightening labor force supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

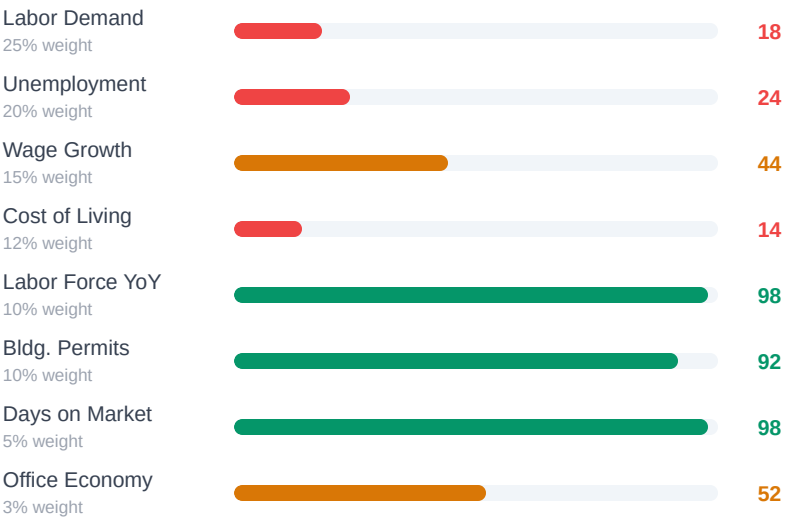
C+

POOR

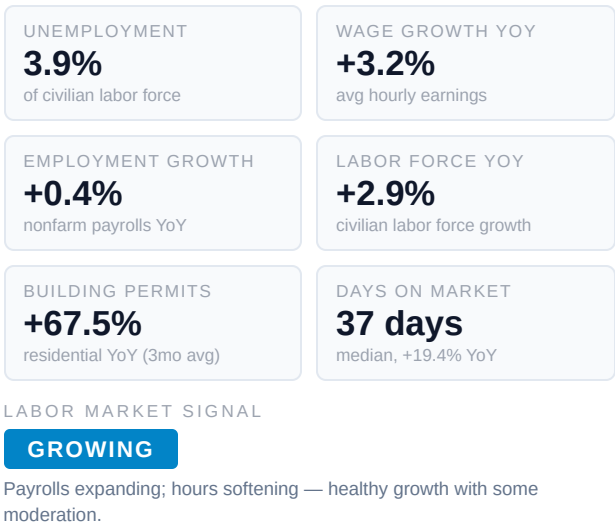
43.1th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 43.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth, with a year-over-year increase of 2.87%, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.68. The labor demand composite score of 3.82, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 0.39% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.026% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the modest job growth is accompanied by a decrease in working hours, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. This scenario suggests that the labor market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire in this city. As a result, companies may face some wage pressure when competing for talent, but it is not as intense as in cities with even lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.21%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate. At the same time, workers in the city are experiencing a modest increase in purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living percentile rank of 14th, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF to wages ratio of 10.68, with PSF at \$486/sqft and wages at \$45.50/hr, highlights the challenge of attracting talent without offering wage premiums. This can be a significant disadvantage for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the city, as they may need to compensate employees for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of 2.87% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid expansion of the labor force supply suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, making it an attractive location

for businesses looking to grow their workforce. The increasing labor pool can provide a competitive advantage for companies operating in the city.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton has increased by 67.46% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This significant rise in building permits indicates that the housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As a result, the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is currently 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 19.4%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile, suggests that the housing market is competitive, but still accessible for relocating workers. The rising days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is ranked near the median at the 52nd percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces. The city's office economy is neither exceptionally strong nor weak, offering a balanced environment for various types of businesses.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a rapidly growing labor force and an expanding housing supply, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for workers. However, the city's high cost of living and moderate wage growth rate pose significant challenges for companies looking to attract and retain talent without offering substantial wage premiums, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully weigh these factors when considering a location in this city.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

C+

POOR

42.2th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.20% and its high wage growth rate of +5.07% year-over-year. These two metrics suggest a tight labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is +0.15% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.117% below trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the small increase in employment is offset by a decrease in hours worked, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.20%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is +5.07% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 68th percentile. This fast wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also means good news for worker purchasing power, as employees see their earnings increase.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City has a cost of living score that ranks it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$172/sqft to \$33.58/hr, or 5.12. This means the city is relatively affordable, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -1.07% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This structural headwind for hiring means businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City are decreasing at a rate of -6.14% year-over-year. This decline in permits signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Oklahoma City are currently sitting on the market for 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.3%. This slower market, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile, means that workers relocating to the city may find a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional talent pool is relatively shallow, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a unique combination of a tight labor market with rising wages and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in the city is the shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which may limit hiring capacity and workforce accommodation.

Fresno

Fresno

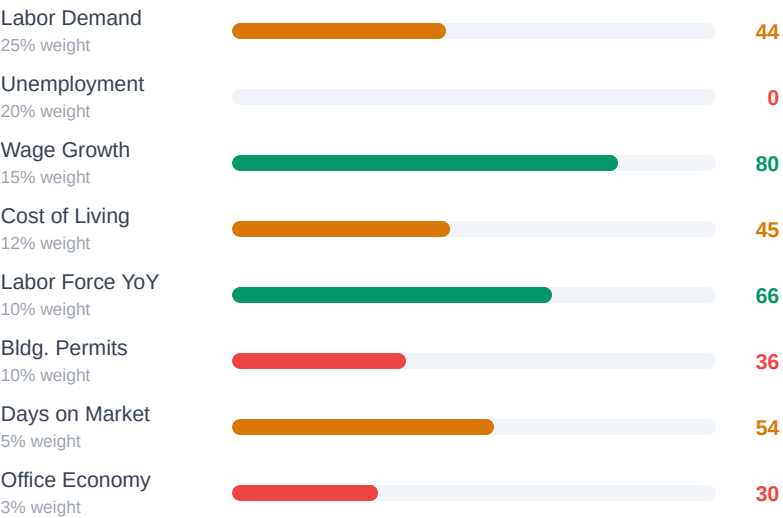
C+

POOR

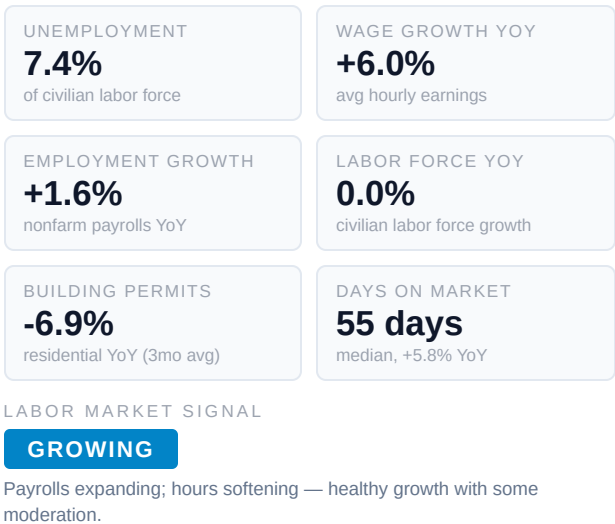
42.2th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 42.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The two metrics that most define this city's current economic character are its high wage growth rate of 5.96% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 7.40%, which suggests a tight labor market. These numbers indicate a city with strong labor cost pressures and potential hiring challenges.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 1.60% year-over-year, while its weekly hours deviation from trend is -2.051%, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.04. This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked below trend, suggesting some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario may lead to fatigue and decreased productivity among the workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.40%, ranking it at the bottom tier with a 0th percentile score. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in Fresno is that it may need to offer higher wages or more competitive benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Fresno is 5.96%, ranking it at the 80th percentile. This is a fast wage growth rate, indicating rising labor costs for employers and increased purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, while workers may enjoy greater disposable income and a higher standard of living.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score ranking it at the 45th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$263/sqft to \$33.62/hr, or 7.82. This suggests that the city is near median in terms of affordability relative to its peers. The stable year-over-year change in PSF vs wages means that the cost of living is not becoming significantly more or less affordable. This near-median affordability score means that Fresno may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno has a year-over-year growth rate of 0.00%, ranking it at the 66th percentile. This indicates a stable labor force supply, neither expanding nor contracting significantly. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses may not face significant structural headwinds or tailwinds in terms of labor force growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Fresno is -6.89%, ranking it at the 36th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could pose a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction in the long term.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Fresno is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.8%. This ranks the city at the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median pace of home sales. For a worker relocating to Fresno, this suggests a relatively competitive but still accessible housing market, with homes selling at a moderate pace.

Office Economy

Fresno's office economy has a composite score ranking it at the 30th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 1.86 out of 5. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that rely on a deep knowledge economy. However, it may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The city of Fresno offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a tight labor market, which may pose challenges for hiring and labor costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the potential for decreased affordability and housing supply, which could impact workforce accommodation and attraction in the long term. Overall, Fresno's economic character is defined by its strong labor market and moderate affordability, making it an attractive location for businesses that can navigate its challenges.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

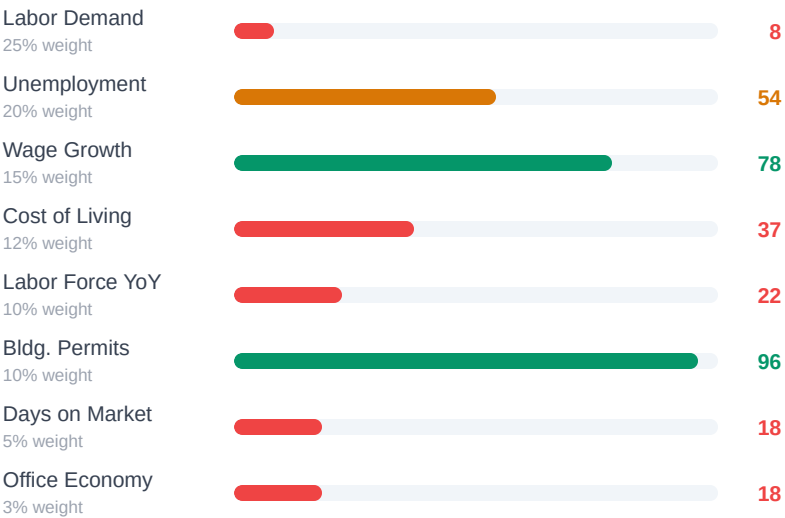
C+

POOR

42.1th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.7%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.9%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.3%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+106.9%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

37 days
median, -2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 42.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.91% in hourly earnings. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.55% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.523%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This metric ranks in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a challenging labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.70%, which is near the median and ranks at the 54th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without excessive wage pressure. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 5.91%, which is above average and ranks at the 78th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which can lead to rising labor costs for employers but also increases worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in this metro area is below average, with a percentile rank of 37, and a PSF to earnings ratio of \$224/sqft to \$35.28/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.35. However, the PSF is increasing by 2.3% year-over-year, which may erode affordability over time. This relatively low cost of living can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require wage premiums to afford the local cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in this metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.31% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This indicates a shrinking labor pool, which can create a structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in this metro area has increased by 106.92% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and support workforce growth in the future. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation, as it may ease housing constraints for their workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in this metro area is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.6%. This ranks in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. For workers relocating to this city, this may mean a competitive and potentially challenging housing market, although the rapid sales pace can also indicate a desirable location.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in this metro area is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests a less deep talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office or professional skills, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, it may be more suitable for industries with different skill requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and expanding housing supply, but it also poses significant challenges due to its weak labor demand and contracting labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential difficulty in hiring and retaining workers due to the shrinking labor pool, which may limit the city's ability to support long-term business growth.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

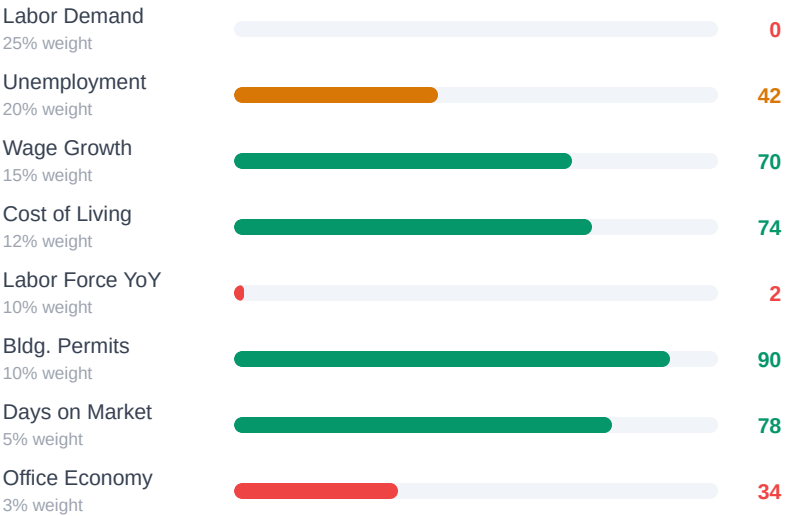
C+

POOR

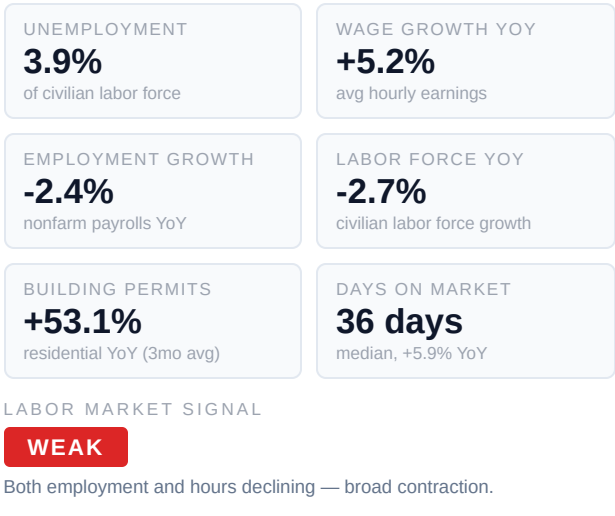
41.8th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 1.50, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.20%. The combination of a -2.44% employment growth rate and a -0.870% weekly hours deviation from trend suggests a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.870% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for workers, but also a potentially weaker local economy.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 3.90%, ranking it near the median at the 42nd percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it neither extremely tight nor very loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding workers may be manageable, but not extremely easy or difficult.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.20% year-over-year, ranking it above average at the 70th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor expenses, while also benefiting from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 74th, Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is more affordable than many of its peers, considering its PSF of \$308/sqft is decreasing by 2.2% year-over-year relative to hourly earnings of \$45.00. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is shrinking at a rate of -2.72% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies or consider relocating to areas with more expansive labor pools.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has increased by 53.15% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This surge in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.9%, ranking it above average at the 78th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market may make it easier to find and purchase a home, but it also signals a less competitive local real estate environment.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 34th, Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, like logistics or manufacturing.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and improving affordability, but its weak labor demand and shrinking labor force pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor pool, which may hinder hiring and growth plans, making it essential to carefully consider recruitment and relocation strategies when evaluating this location.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

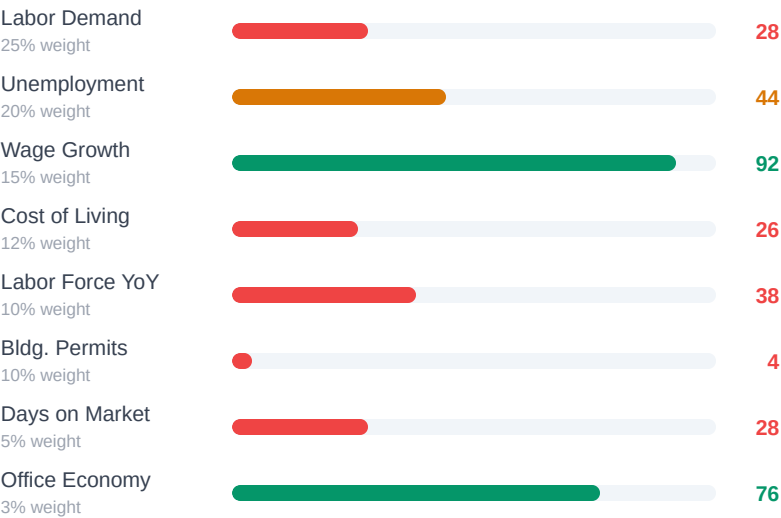
C+

POOR

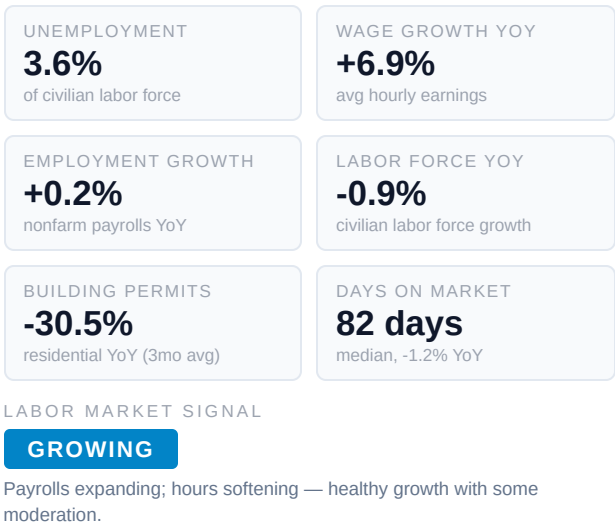
40.7th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.93%, and its struggling labor demand, which has a composite score of 4.29, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.18% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.262% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The below-average labor demand composite score of 4.29 further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.60%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 6.93%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means good news for worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for increased labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score ranking below average at the 26th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$357/sqft to \$34.40/hr, or 10.38. Although the PSF is falling by 1.1% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is contracting at a rate of -0.93% year-over-year. This means that the workforce supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may face challenges in finding the talent they need in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -30.46%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it harder for the workforce to find accommodation. This trend poses a risk to future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 82 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.2%. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The competitive housing market may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking above average at the 76th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that require a knowledgeable workforce. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented needs.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it harder to attract and retain talent.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C+

POOR

39.2th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		12
25% weight		
Unemployment		30
20% weight		
Wage Growth		20
15% weight		
Cost of Living		94
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		62
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		58
10% weight		
Days on Market		42
5% weight		
Office Economy		60
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.3% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.6% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +5.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 61 days median, -1.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.65 ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, with a ratio of \$173/sqft to \$32.51/hr, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's current economic landscape, with the former indicating a sluggish job market and the latter suggesting an attractive environment for talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +0.61% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -2.350% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the job market is not expanding rapidly, and the hours worked are below the trend, suggesting a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. This metric ranks in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, highlighting the city's struggle with labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.10%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This indicates that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but it also means that local consumer demand may be weaker. With an unemployment rate above the national average, businesses may find it relatively easier to staff, but they should also be aware of the potential impact on local demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +1.33%, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit gradually. This wage growth rate may not be high enough to drive significant economic expansion but is still a positive sign for the local workforce.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a cost of living ratio of \$173/sqft to \$32.51/hr, with the price per square foot falling -5.0% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This makes the city highly affordable relative to its peers, which is a significant advantage for talent attraction, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to account for the cost of living. The falling price per square foot is a key driver of this affordability, making the city an attractive option for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of -0.11% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. Although this growth rate is negative, indicating a contracting labor pool, the city's labor force is still relatively stable compared to its peers. This contraction may pose a structural headwind for hiring, but the city's overall labor market remains relatively resilient.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is increasing by +5.83% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future affordability may improve, making it easier for the workforce to find accommodation. However, the pace of growth is not exceptionally high, indicating a gradual improvement in housing supply.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 61 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.6%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market may be competitive, but the decreasing days on market suggest that it is still accessible, with homes selling relatively quickly.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has an office economy share of 2.98, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and headquarters decisions. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with a strong industrial or logistics component, as its economy is more geared towards knowledge-based sectors.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's sluggish labor demand, which may limit the pace of economic expansion and pose challenges for hiring and workforce growth.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

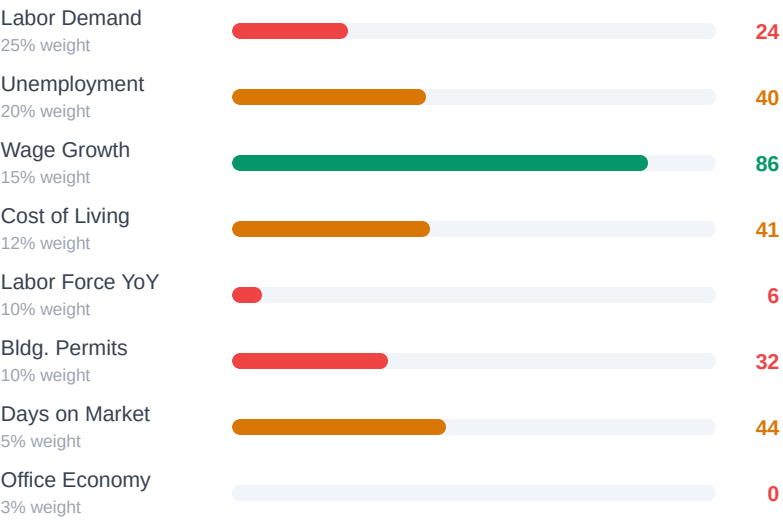
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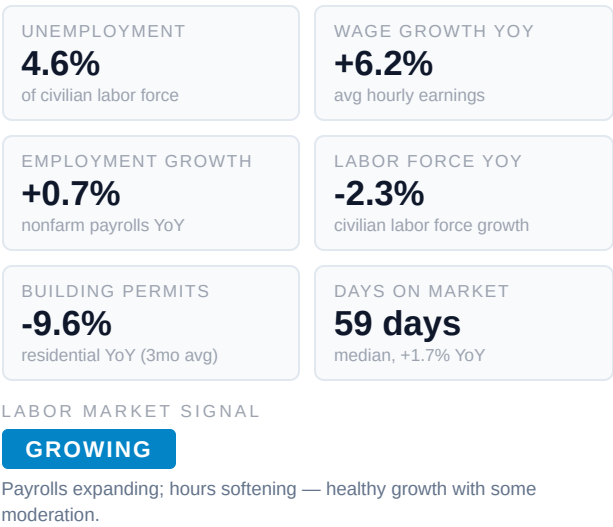
37.8th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.00, which is below average. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth of +6.17% year-over-year and its weak labor force growth of -2.31% year-over-year. These two metrics signal a complex labor market with rising costs and shrinking supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is +0.65% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -1.215% below the city's own trend, indicating a labor demand composite score of 4.00, which is below average. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The below-average labor demand suggests that the city's job market is not as robust as others.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 4.60%, which is near the median, ranking 40th percentile. This rate indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that there may be a decent pool of available workers, but wage pressure is not extremely high.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +6.17%, which is in the top tier, ranking 86th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may face higher labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living is near median, with a percentile rank of 41st, and a PSF to earnings ratio of \$335/sqft to \$35.56/hr, which is 9.42. The fact that PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year is a key driver of the city's affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -2.31%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 6th percentile. This contracting labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity may be constrained, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -9.60%, which is below average, ranking 32nd percentile. This decline in building permits signals that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a

growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 0.22, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 0th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. Instead, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers a complex labor market with strong wage growth, but also shrinking labor force supply and tightening housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business decision-maker is the city's limited labor force growth, which may lead to hiring challenges and rising labor costs. Despite these challenges, the city's relatively affordable cost of living and accessible housing market may still attract workers and businesses looking for a more affordable alternative.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

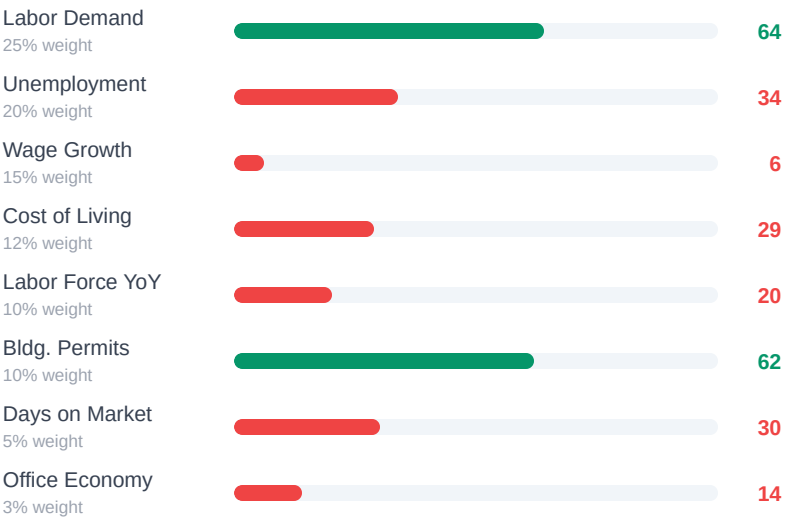
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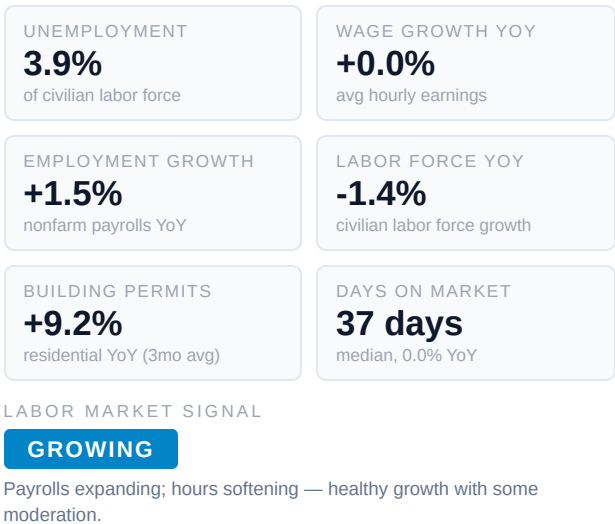
37.2th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of strengths and weaknesses. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with an above-average composite score of 5.63, and its stagnant wage growth, at just +0.01% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with some job market momentum but significant pressure on labor costs and worker purchasing power.

Labor Demand

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an employment growth rate of +1.46% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of -0.718% from its own trend, combining for an above-average labor demand composite score. This signals a genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, indicating a strong job market. The combination of these metrics suggests that businesses can expect to find a relatively robust labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is 3.90%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is +0.01%, ranking at the bottom tier of the 6th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in worker purchasing power. This could be a concern for businesses relying on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 29th percentile, with a PSF of \$212/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$39.46, resulting in a ratio of 5.37. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year slightly mitigates this, but the overall affordability remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.38% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may find it increasingly

difficult to find the talent they need. This could limit the city's appeal for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Building Permits

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has seen a +9.15% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which could enhance affordability and make the city more attractive for workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area is 37 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable year-over-year direction suggests a balanced market rather than an overheated one.

Office Economy

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has a professional and office worker share that ranks at the bottom tier of the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, but it may be more appropriate for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers a mixed bag for businesses, with some strengths in labor demand and building permits, but significant challenges in wage growth, cost of living, and labor force contraction. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which could limit the city's appeal for businesses looking to expand or relocate, and necessitates careful consideration of talent attraction and retention strategies.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

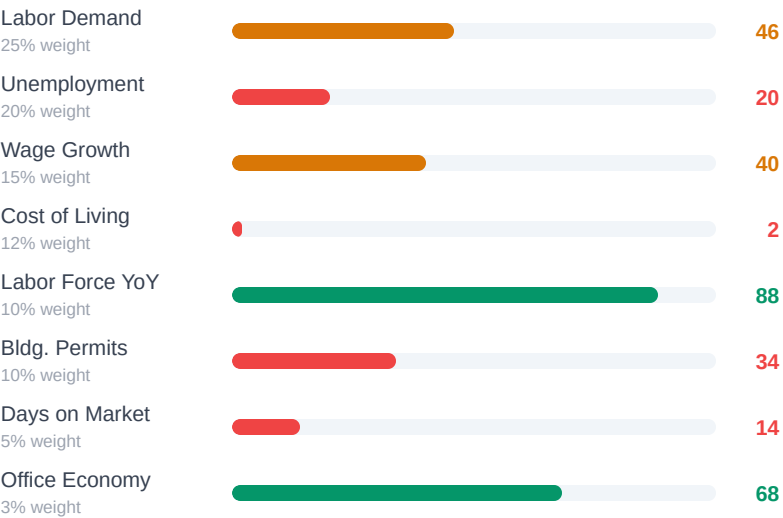
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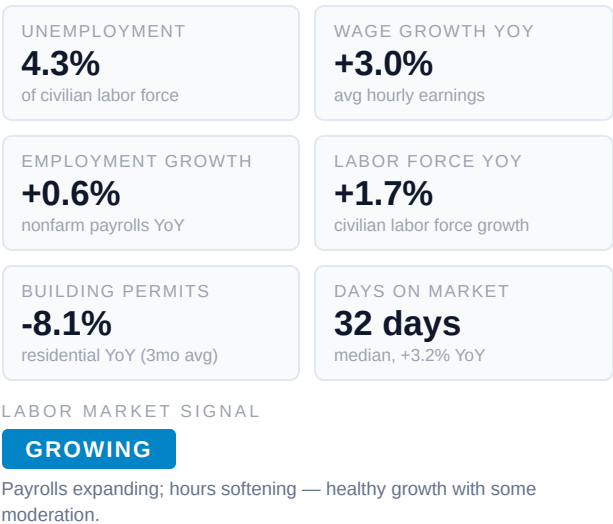
36.7th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.11. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.15. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.025% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate expansion of labor demand, with some genuine demand for jobs, but not at a rate that is significantly above trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.11 is near the median, indicating a stable but not exceptional job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, which is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. Companies looking to staff up in this city may face challenges in finding available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +3.00%, which is near the median, ranking in the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the wage growth is not strong enough to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living percentile rank of 2, indicating that it is one of the more expensive cities in the US, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.15 and a year-over-year increase in PSF of 8.9%. This means that the city is relatively unaffordable, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may be a significant deterrent for businesses looking to relocate or expand in this city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 88th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive environment for hiring and business growth. Companies looking to staff up in this city may find a growing pool of available workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Providence-Warwick is -8.13%, which is below average, ranking in the 34th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This could be a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain talent in the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Providence-Warwick is 32 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.2%. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking in the 14th percentile, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the housing market, rather than a significant decline in demand.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy percentile rank of 68, indicating a deep professional talent pool, with 3.10 out of 5 composite score. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The city's professional workforce is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a knowledgeable and skilled labor pool.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers a growing labor force and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses in certain sectors. However, the city's high cost of living and tightening housing supply are significant concerns that may impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent, and should be carefully considered by decision-makers.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

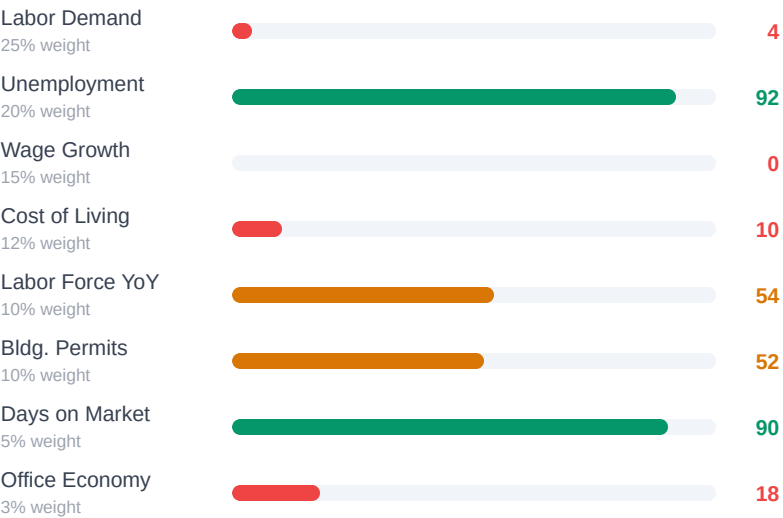
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VERY POOR

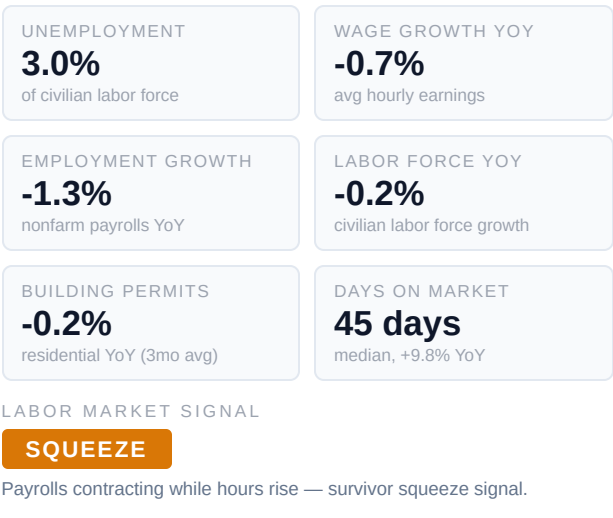
36.3th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, specifically a -1.33% employment growth rate and -0.71% year-over-year wage growth. The combination of these metrics signals a challenging economic environment. The city's labor market is characterized by a low unemployment rate of 3.00%, but this is paired with negative employment growth and stagnant wages.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.33%, indicating a contraction in the number of jobs available, while the weekly hours deviation from the 12-month baseline is +0.298%, suggesting that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, indicative of a survivor squeeze. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market. The labor demand composite score of 2.14 falls in the bottom tier, at the 4th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.00%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This tight market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer available workers, and may experience upward pressure on wages. The 92nd percentile rank for unemployment suggests that the market has very little slack.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -0.71%, indicating stagnant or even declining wages. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not increasing, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. The bottom-tier percentile rank for wage growth, at 0th percentile, underscores the challenges in this aspect of the labor market.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score that places it in the bottom tier, at the 10th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$167/sqft to \$32.76/hr, or 5.10. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, especially since PSF is rising by 5.0% year-over-year. The high cost of living, relative to wages, may hinder talent attraction without offering wage premiums to offset the expense.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is growing at a rate of -0.25% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor force supply. This contraction suggests that the hiring capacity may be structurally constrained, making it challenging for

businesses to find and recruit new talent. The near-median percentile rank of 54th percentile for labor force growth, however, suggests that this constraint is not as severe as in other metrics.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -0.22%, indicating a slight tightening in the housing supply. This decrease in building permits may signal future affordability challenges and potential difficulties in accommodating a growing workforce, as the supply of new housing is not expanding to meet demand. The near-median percentile rank of 52nd percentile for building permits suggests a moderate level of developer confidence.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 9.8%. This increase, coupled with the top-tier percentile rank of 90th percentile, indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, placing it in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests that the city has a less deep talent pool in these areas, making it less suited for businesses that require a strong presence of tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations. The city may be more suited for industries that are less dependent on professional and office workers.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses, with a tight labor market and low unemployment rate being offset by stagnant wage growth, a high cost of living, and a contracting labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering this location is the challenging labor market dynamics, which could hinder hiring and talent attraction efforts. Overall, businesses must carefully weigh these factors when deciding whether to locate in this metro area.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

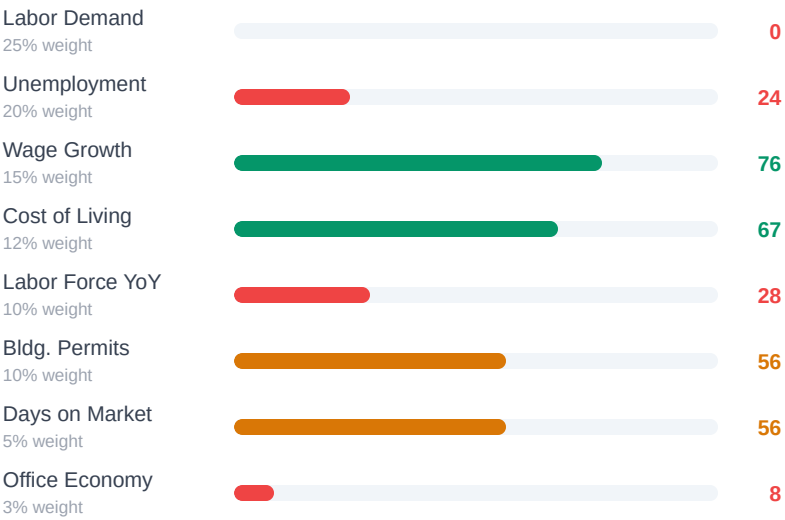
C

VERY POOR

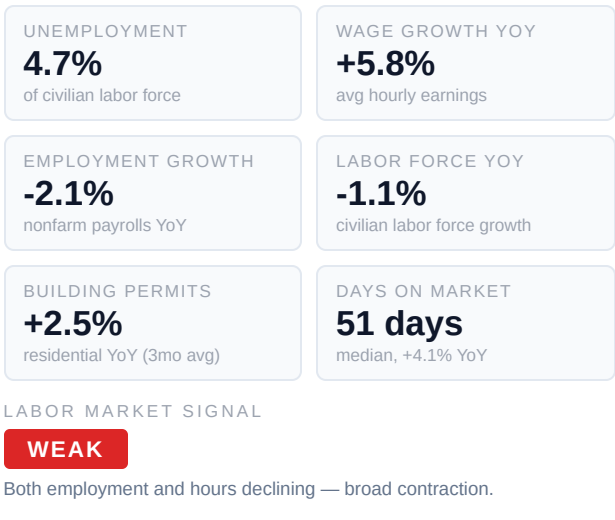
35.7th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and high wage growth. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, combining a -2.07% employment growth rate and a -0.245% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with a wage growth rate of +5.82%, suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -2.07% and weekly hours deviation of -0.245% from the city's own trend indicate a contraction in labor demand, signaling that the city is experiencing a period of job losses and reduced working hours. This combination suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion, instead pointing to a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 1.50 falls into the bottom tier, reinforcing this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.70% places the city below the average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This indicates that while the market is not extremely tight, there is some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may still face some competition for talent, albeit less than in markets with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.82% is above average, ranking at the 76th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates good worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$309/sqft to \$42.08/hr, and a PSF that is falling by -1.9% YoY, the city ranks at the 67th percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is more affordable relative to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without needing wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of -1.14% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor force supply. This negative growth rate suggests that the workforce pool is shrinking, presenting a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +2.48%, which is near the median. This slight increase suggests that housing supply is slowly expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. However, the rate of increase is modest, indicating that significant supply constraints are not being rapidly addressed.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +4.1%. This indicates a slowing market where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is becoming more accessible, as there is less competition and pressure to act quickly on housing decisions.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 0.68, ranking at the 8th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas, making the city less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions. Instead, the economy may be more industrial or logistics-dominant.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a complex mix of high wage growth and relatively low labor demand, suggesting that while labor costs may be rising, the pool of available workers might be shrinking. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering this location is the shrinking labor force and the potential for a survivor squeeze, which could impact hiring capacity and business expansion plans.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

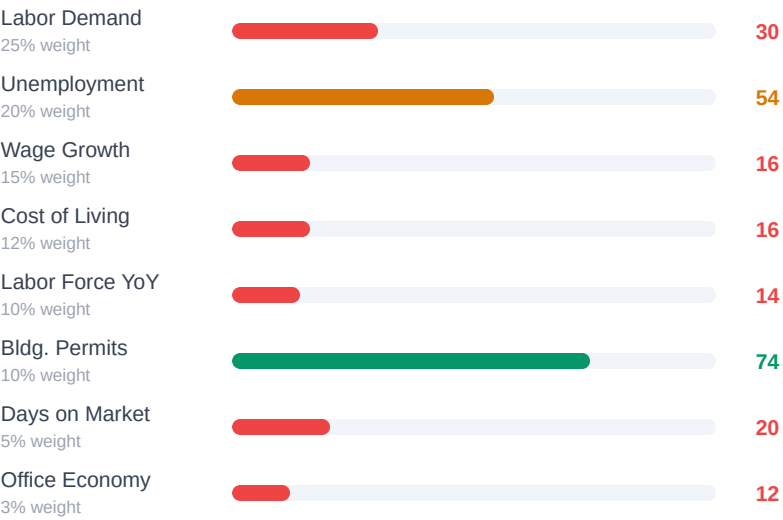
C

VERY POOR

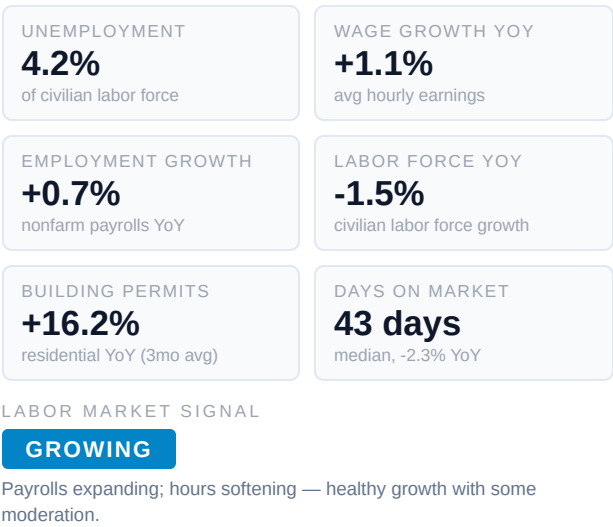
32.8th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 32.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, which are 30th percentile and 16th percentile, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 4.38 and wage growth of +1.15% year-over-year are key metrics defining this city's current economic character. These numbers indicate a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is +0.69% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.889% below the city's own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the job market is not as strong as the employment growth rate alone might indicate. The labor demand composite score of 4.38 is below average, ranking 30th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 4.20%, which is near the median, ranking 54th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant slack nor extreme tightness. For a business trying to hire in this market, the moderate unemployment rate means that finding talent may not be overly difficult, but it also doesn't indicate a surplus of highly competitive candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth is +1.15%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 16th percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals moderate labor costs for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. The slow wage growth environment may help keep labor costs flat but could also indicate weaker consumer demand due to limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$343/sqft to \$37.97/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.03, and a percentile rank of 16th, Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums could be challenging due to the high cost of living. The city's affordability is a concern for businesses looking to relocate or expand without significantly increasing compensation packages.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is shrinking at a rate of -1.52% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This negative growth rate poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding the talent they need due to this shrinking labor force.

Building Permits

Residential building permits are increasing by +16.17% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking 74th percentile. This rise in permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, potentially improving affordability and accommodating a growing workforce. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for 43 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.3%. This relatively fast market, ranking below average at the 20th percentile, indicates a competitive environment for homebuyers, which could make it tough for relocating workers to find and secure housing quickly.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office sector jobs is 0.96, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions that require deep knowledge-economy talent. The city's economy is more industrial or logistics-dominant, which may be better suited for businesses in those sectors.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses considering relocation or expansion, with challenges in labor demand, wage growth, and cost of living being significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which poses a long-term challenge for hiring and talent acquisition. Despite some positive signs like an increase in building permits, the overall economic environment suggests caution and careful consideration of these factors in any business location decision.

Richmond

Richmond

C

VERY POOR

32.6th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		10
Unemployment 20% weight		60
Wage Growth 15% weight		36
Cost of Living 12% weight		22
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		32
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		60
Days on Market 5% weight		0
Office Economy 3% weight		26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.5% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +8.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 37 days median, -13.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 32.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.05, which is in the bottom tier. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high cost of living, with an employment growth rate of -0.72% and a cost of living ratio of 6.47. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.72%, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.245%, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The low labor demand composite score of 3.05 further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.50%, which is at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, and wage pressure may be higher. However, the market is not extremely tight, and there is still some slack.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Richmond is +2.59%, which is below average, ranking at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living ratio of 6.47, with a PSF of \$229/sqft and hourly earnings of \$35.37, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive, and the cost of living is a significant concern. The PSF is increasing by 1.3% year-over-year, making it even more challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -0.98% year-over-year, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This implies that the labor pool is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond is increasing by 8.22% year-over-year, ranking at the 60th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 13.9%, ranking at the 0th percentile. This extremely fast market means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find accommodation.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Richmond is 1.70, ranking at the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

In conclusion, Richmond offers a challenging business environment, with low labor demand and high cost of living being the most significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor pool, which may limit hiring capacity and business expansion.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

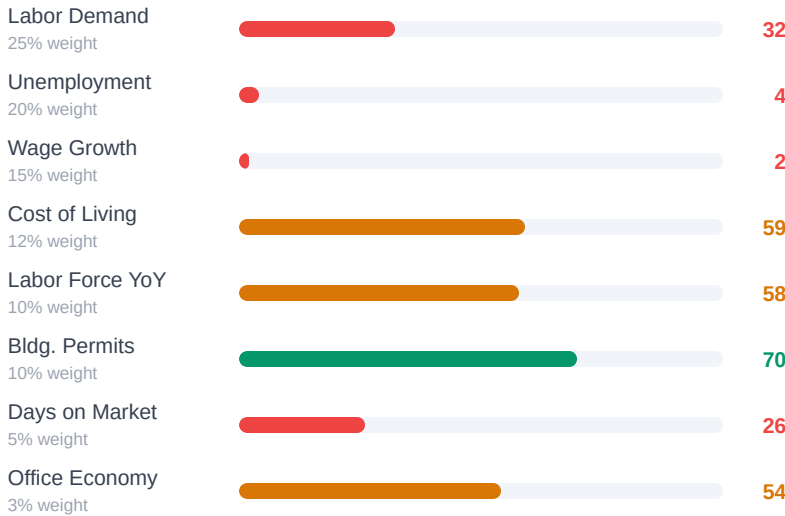
C-

CRITICAL

31.9th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

-0.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.3%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.1%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+15.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

59 days

median, -11.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.70% and its stagnant wage growth of -0.68% year-over-year, which signal a tight labor market with weak wage pressure. These metrics suggest that Jacksonville's economy is characterized by a scarcity of labor and limited upward mobility for workers.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is 0.33% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.372% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours worked are below trend. This suggests that businesses may not be expanding their operations or hiring new workers at a rapid pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.70%, which is in the bottom tier of the percentile rankings, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for a limited pool of workers, leading to potential wage pressure and hiring challenges. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer higher wages or more attractive benefits to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Jacksonville is -0.68% year-over-year, indicating stagnant or even declining wages. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers have limited bargaining power and may not have the purchasing power to drive local consumer demand. As a result, businesses may not see significant increases in labor costs, but they may also not benefit from a highly paid and consumer-driven local economy.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score that ranks it 59th percentile, with a PSF of \$217/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.43/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.96. This suggests that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither extremely expensive nor very affordable. The fact that PSF is falling -2.7% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset the cost of living, as the city's affordability is relatively neutral compared to its peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of -0.15% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is not expanding, which could create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion in the city. As the labor force is not growing, businesses may face challenges in finding new workers to fill open positions or support expansion plans.

Building Permits

Building permits in Jacksonville are increasing by 15.03% year-over-year, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is rising, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better affordability and easier workforce accommodation. As housing supply increases, the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses alike, potentially easing some of the labor market pressures.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Jacksonville is 59 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -11.9%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market where homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The fast pace of the market suggests that workers may need to act quickly to secure housing, and businesses may need to consider this when relocating employees or planning expansions.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share ranks 54th percentile, indicating a near-median depth of talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a moderate level of professional and office skills, but may not be the best fit for businesses requiring highly specialized or abundant tech, finance, or consulting talent. The city's office economy is neither extremely strong nor weak, making it a potential location for a variety of businesses, but perhaps not the most competitive for those requiring a deep pool of highly specialized workers.

The city of Jacksonville offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and stagnant wage growth, which can be both a challenge and an opportunity. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the limited labor pool and potential hiring challenges, which could hinder expansion plans or require significant investments in talent attraction and retention strategies.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

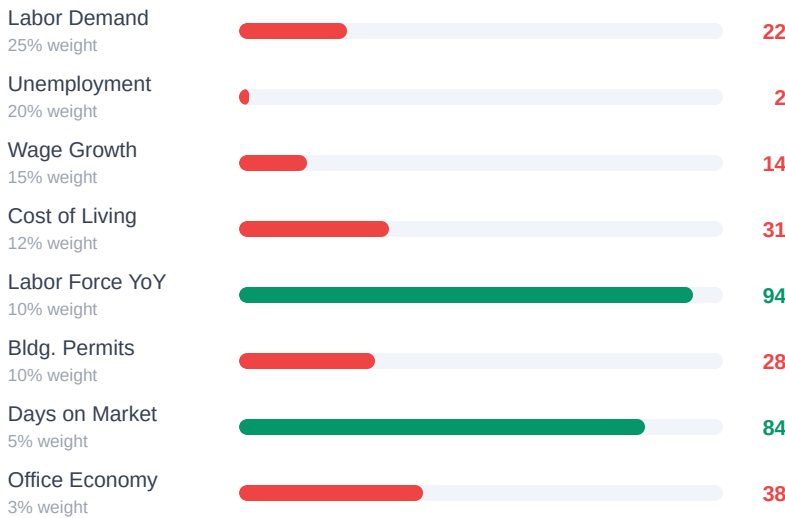
C-

CRITICAL

29.2th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.1%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+2.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-11.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days
median, +8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 29.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.96 ranking it in the 22th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 5.50%, which ranks it in the 2th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.24% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.219% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are not increasing, which may lead to a surplus of workers. This scenario does not suggest genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.50%, ranking it in the 2th percentile, which means the market has significant slack. This implies that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. Companies looking to staff up may find a larger pool of available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.06%, ranking it in the 14th percentile, which indicates stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. Employers may benefit from a flat cost environment, but workers may have limited bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score ranking it in the 31th percentile, with a PSF of \$186/sqft and an hourly earnings rate of \$36.54, resulting in a ratio of 5.09. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that the PSF is not falling year-over-year suggests that affordability is not improving. This may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's affordability is not a significant advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +2.21% year-over-year, ranking it in the 94th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force can accommodate the needs of expanding companies.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has decreased by -10.99% year-over-year, ranking it in the 28th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This could be a concern for businesses relying on a mobile workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 38 days, with an 8.6% year-over-year increase, ranking it in the 84th percentile. This means the market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this slowing market may also indicate weakening demand.

Office Economy

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has an office economy score ranking it in the 38th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a highly specialized or knowledge-economy dominant workforce, such as industrial or logistics companies. It may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a slowing housing market, which may provide opportunities for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and high unemployment rate, which may signal a challenging economic environment and require careful consideration of the local market's strengths and weaknesses.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

D

EMERGENCY

25.5th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		40
25% weight		
Unemployment		6
20% weight		
Wage Growth		46
15% weight		
Cost of Living		35
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		12
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		6
10% weight		
Days on Market		10
5% weight		
Office Economy		32
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -28.6% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 33 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 25.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.84, near the median. The city's current economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 4.90% and its negative labor force growth rate of -1.66% YoY. These metrics signal significant challenges in the local labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.12% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.375% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score. This combination signals a modest expansion of genuine demand, but the low overall growth rate suggests a lack of strong job market momentum. The labor demand is not particularly robust, given the low employment growth rate.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. The practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that they may have a larger pool of potential candidates to choose from.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.22%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a moderate pace. The wage growth is not stagnant, but it is also not exceptionally high, providing a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living percentile rank of 35th, with a PSF of \$221/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$37.09/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.96, which is below average. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The affordability of the city can help businesses attract and retain workers without incurring high labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -1.66% YoY, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing.

The negative labor force growth rate poses a significant challenge for businesses looking to expand their workforce in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is -28.57%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This decline signals a potential supply squeeze in the future, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. The falling building permits suggest that the city's housing market may become less accommodating to new residents.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 33 days, with a YoY direction of +0.0%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This means that homes are selling relatively quickly, making the market competitive for relocating workers. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not becoming more accessible to buyers, which could pose challenges for workers looking to relocate to the area.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 1.92, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and worst suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers. The city's office economy is not particularly strong, which may limit its appeal to certain types of businesses.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate wage growth environment, but it is constrained by a loose labor market, a shrinking labor force, and a declining housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering this location is the negative labor force growth rate, which poses a significant challenge for hiring and expanding a workforce in the area.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

D

EMERGENCY

20.3th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.4%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-6.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-15.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

33 days
median, -8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 20.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting significant economic challenges. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 3.84, which is in the 20th percentile, and its extremely low labor force growth rate of -6.22% YoY. These metrics signal a struggling job market with limited workforce expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.33% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.923% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a genuine demand contraction, rather than a survivor squeeze, as both jobs and hours are declining. The labor demand composite score of 3.84, in the 20th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.40%, which is in the 36th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. While this is not extremely high, it suggests that the market is not particularly tight, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +2.03%, which is in the 30th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit slowly. The wage growth is not stagnant, but it is also not fast enough to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living score in the 8th percentile, with a PSF of \$224/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.46/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.90. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, especially since PSF is rising 6.2% YoY. The low percentile rank suggests that the city is less affordable than most of its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -6.22% YoY, which is in the 0th percentile, indicating a severe structural headwind for hiring. This decline in labor force supply will make it increasingly difficult for businesses to find and hire qualified workers, limiting their capacity for growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is declining by -15.25% YoY, which is in the 22nd percentile, signaling a tightening of the housing supply. This reduction in new housing construction will likely lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for available housing, making it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 33 days, with a YoY decline of -8.3%, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. However, the 2nd percentile rank suggests that homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find suitable housing. This fast market may pose challenges for businesses trying to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 0.74, which is in the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and is less suitable for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers a relatively low-cost business environment, but its struggling job market, limited workforce expansion, and decreasing affordability pose significant risks for businesses considering relocation. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the city's extremely low labor force growth rate, which will limit the availability of qualified workers and hinder business growth.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

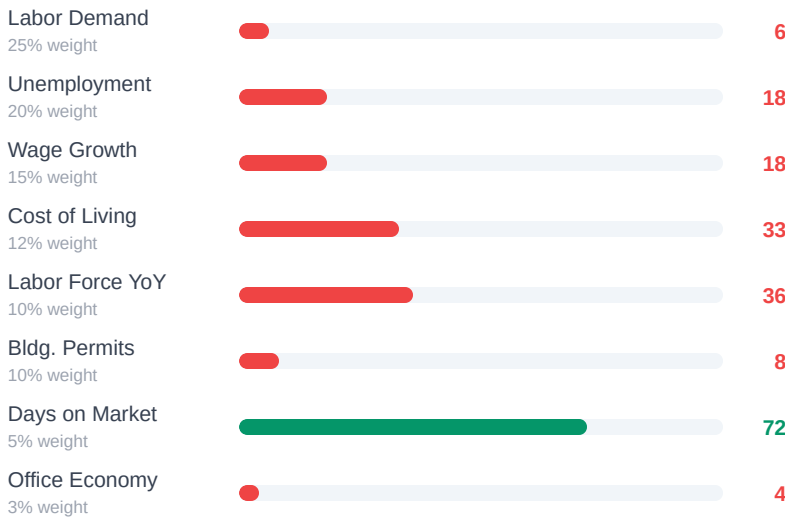
D

EMERGENCY

19.8th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.2%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.0%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-27.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days

median, +5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 19.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.57. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with employment growth at -0.47% year-over-year, and its relatively high unemployment rate of 4.60%. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.47% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 1.071% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This metric ranks in the bottom tier, at the 6th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.60%, which is relatively high, indicating some slack in the labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The unemployment rate ranks in the bottom tier, at the 18th percentile.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.17%, which is relatively slow. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The wage growth rate ranks in the bottom tier, at the 18th percentile.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living ratio of \$179/sqft to \$30.70/hr, with a percentile rank of 33. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable, with a lower cost of living compared to peers. This can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is contracting at a rate of -0.96% year-over-year. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring. The labor force growth rate ranks below average, at the 36th percentile.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by -27.55% year-over-year. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The building permits metric ranks in the bottom tier, at the 8th percentile.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.3%. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, this can be a more accessible market, with less competition for housing.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.44, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a slower housing market, which can be advantages for businesses looking to relocate or expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's weak labor demand and tightening housing supply, which can create challenges in hiring and accommodating a growing workforce. Overall, businesses should carefully consider these factors before making a location decision.